

ABOUT 5,000 MISSING; 13,093 RESCUED; OVER 32,000 PEOPLE AFFECTED

Nepal Death Toll Rises to 1,295; Two Workers Rescued Alive from Tunnel

Agencies

Kathmandu: The death toll due to flash floods in Nepal rose to 1,295 on Friday as more bodies were recovered from the affected areas while two men were rescued alive from a tunnel at the Trishuli 3A hydropower project after being trapped for nine days.

The joint command of security forces is actively conducting search and rescue operations for the estimated 5,000 missing. So far, 13,093 people have been rescued from the affected areas. The devastating flash floods in Nepal have affected more than 32,000 people and damaged roads, bridges, schools and healthcare facilities, according to a preliminary government report released on Friday.

The two men rescued alive from the tunnel were identified as Kabir Maharjan, 45, a mechanical supervisor on the project, and Sanjay Sah, 30, a foreman, according to the Public Relations Directorate of the Nepal Army. Maharjan was flown to Nepal Army Hospital in Chhauni, Kathmandu, and his condition is said to be critical, while Sah is under treatment at the Trishuli hospital in Nuwakot, according to Raja Ram Basnet, Nepali Army spokesperson.

Sah, who is from Saptari district in Madhesh province, told security personnel that he was chanting 'Hare Krishna' mantra for the last nine days while trapped inside the tunnel.

Meanwhile, the sixth and seventh relief flights from India carrying 21.5 tonnes of relief materials arrived in Kathmandu on Thursday night. "India's support to Nepal's relief efforts for Rasuwa flash flood continues: 6th and 7th relief flights (C-130Js) arrived in Kathmandu tonight carrying 21.5 tonnes of relief assistance, including forensic



AFTER 9 DAYS
Two men rescued alive from the tunnel identified as Kabir Maharjan, 45, a mechanical supervisor, and Sanjay Sah, 30, a foreman

'1,907 HAVE SAFELY CROSSED OVER TO NEPAL FROM CHINA' '275 Indian Nationals Remain Missing'

NEW DELHI: Two hundred seventy-five Indians remained missing while 166 others were rescued following the devastating flash floods along the Nepal-Tibet border, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said on Friday. It said that 1,907 Indian nationals have safely crossed over to Nepal from China. MEA spokesman Randhir Jaiswal said India supplied around 95 tonnes of relief material to Nepal. "275 Indian nationals remain missing. We continue to be in close touch with the Nepali government," Jaiswal said at his regular media briefing. "We deeply appreciate the efforts of the Nepalese authorities in this regard. So far, 166 Indian nationals have been rescued and 1,907 Indian nationals have safely crossed into Nepal from China," he said. —PTI

Developed countries who historically are responsible for the emissions & have contributed overwhelmingly to this crisis, must take lead in reducing emissions and supporting developing countries by way of finance and technology transfer to meet this challenge
RANDHIR JAISWAL
MEA Spokesperson

kits and medical supplies," India's ambassador to Nepal Naveen Srivastava said in a post on X. "These materials were handed over to Nepal, and will help strengthen ongoing Nepali relief and rescue efforts and support communities affected by Rasuwa floods," he added.

Around 600 children remain unaccounted for in Nepal's Rasuwa and Nuwakot districts. The disaster has also taken a toll on teachers and school staff. Education units confirmed that 22 teachers and school staff members remain missing across both districts.

Australian disaster response specialists left for Nepal on Friday to join the search for survivors, as the Australian government expressed "serious concerns" for the welfare of its 36 missing citizens.

The UN and humanitarian partners have launched a \$49.6 million flash appeal to deliver life-saving relief to over 84,000 people affected by the floods.



Victim's daughter Nishu Azad at Delhi Police station — ANI

Influencer Who Bragged About Cracking Man's Skull Detained After CJP Protest

Press Trust Of India

New Delhi: Delhi Police detained Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in UP on Friday, hours after the Cockerach Janta Party staged a protest outside the Parliament Street police station demanding his arrest for assaulting a student's father, a crime he bragged about in an interview.

The detention came after CJP representatives, accompanied by Azad Samaj Party (Kanshi Ram) chief and Nagina MP Chandrashekhar Azad and MP Pappu Yadav, met police officials and were assured that action would be taken against Bhardwaj within 72 hours.

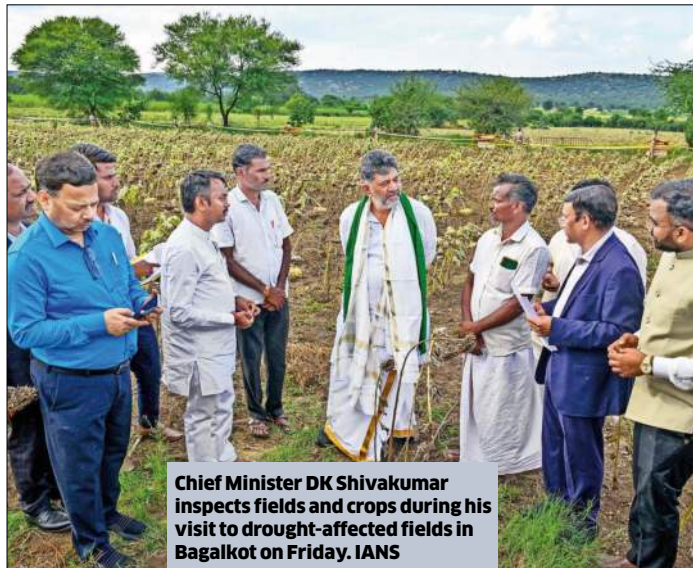
The delegation sought the addition of attempt-to-murder, criminal intimidation and SC/ST Act provisions to the case and demanded a separate FIR over alleged rape threats, abuse and objectionable images targeting the assault victim Sanjay Kumar's daughter Nishu. Bhardwaj, who describes himself as a "kattar" (staunch) Hindu, claimed in an interview that he cracked the skull of Nishu's father and got away with it because of his political connections.

Bhardwaj, who describes himself as a "kattar" (staunch) Hindu, claimed in an interview that he cracked the skull of Nishu's father and got away with it because of his political connections, causing widespread outrage on social media.

"I cracked the skull of Nishu's father... But I was not even jailed. The world should know this. I was out and about through the night," Bhardwaj said in the interview.

Police sources said Bhardwaj fled from Naithla village on a Royal Enfield motorcycle towards Khurja before a police team reached there to apprehend him. He was wearing a helmet to conceal his identity, they said.

Police said Kumar was medically examined at RML Hospital and his injuries were opined to be simple in nature.



Chief Minister DK Shivakumar inspects fields and crops during his visit to drought-affected fields in Bagalkot on Friday. IANS

STATE STARING AT POSSIBLE DRINKING WATER SHORTAGE

Over 100 Taluks Face Drought; CM to Meet PM to Seek Farm Relief

A plane was deployed to carry out cloud seeding by sending rain-inducing chemicals into clouds

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: Chief minister DK Shivakumar on Friday said he would lead an all-party delegation to Prime Minister Narendra Modi to seek a waiver of farm loans in Karnataka amid drought conditions in more than 100 taluks.

He said the Centre should share the burden of providing relief to farmers, arguing that Modi himself had acknowledged the drought situation.

He urged BJP state president BY Vijayendra, leader of the opposition in the state assembly R Ashoka and other opposition leaders to join the delegation and press the Centre for a loan waiver.

The state government has also stepped up drought relief measures, including cloud-seeding operations aimed at augmenting rainfall. Water resources minister N Cheluvarayaswamy flagged off a plane from HAL airport in Bengaluru on Friday to carry out cloud seeding by releasing rain-inducing chemicals into clouds.

The government expects rainfall to occur within 30-60 minutes of the cloud-seeding process and has allocated ₹28.52 crore for the project. Shivakumar, who undertook an aerial survey of drought-hit areas, said he had directed ministers to visit districts assigned to them, meet affected people and monitor relief measures. The government is preparing detailed reports on the drought situation to submit to the Centre and seek immediate financial assistance.

Cheluvarayaswamy said the cloud-seeding exercise was aimed at mitigating the water crisis as the southwest monsoon is expected to withdraw this month.

Karnataka has received deficient rainfall this year, raising concerns over drinking water availability if adequate water is not conserved before the monsoon ends.

The state undertook a similar cloud-seeding exercise about two decades ago, with a reported success rate of 27%.

'BJP IS ANTI-DEVELOPMENT' DK Defends Parks Bill; Move Meant to Initiate Debate

PTI

Bengaluru: Chief Minister DK Shivakumar on Friday defended his government's decision to withdraw the contentious Parks Bill, which allows 5% of park and garden land to be used for public infrastructure and utility projects, saying the move was meant to facilitate a debate and make people aware of its objectives. He criticised the BJP for claiming victory over the Bill's withdrawal, calling the party "anti-development".

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Maldives Awards Contract for Phase 1 of Thilafushi Port to A Chinese Company

Dipanjn Roy Chaudhury

New Delhi: The Maldives has renewed its commitment to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port with India, signing a memorandum of understanding (MoU) with a Chinese company for development of the first phase of the project. The development has triggered alarm bells in the strategic community as it can boost China's presence in India's southern neighbourhood.

Maldives Ports Limited recently signed an MoU with China Harbour Engineering Company (CHEC), awarding the port project on a single nomination basis even as CHEC has a patchy track record. Besides Sri Lanka's Hambantota Port, CHEC has been involved in ports in South

MALDIVES GOES BACK ON ITS COMMITMENT

In 2024, during the Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu's India visit, the two sides had announced plans to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port to decongest the Male Port

America, Kenya and the Pacific, and has been infamous for financial and project mismanagement, according to people familiar with the matter.

CHEC and its parent company, CCCC, have been involved in the Guyana Airport Project, the Nivasha Inland Container Depot in Kenya and the Nauru Port Redevelopment project, among others.

A strategic affairs expert said on

condition of anonymity that CHEC has a record of delivering projects that have created governance, fiscal, environmental, political and strategic risks.

The decision to engage CHEC at a time when the Maldivian economy is in a precarious position, accentuated by the West Asian conflict, has also raised eyebrows. "The Maldives' current account deficit and fiscal deficit

are projected to increase substantially this year while gross domestic product growth is expected to dip below 1% compared to 6% last year.

In 2024, during the Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu's India visit, the two sides had announced plans to jointly develop the Thilafushi Port to decongest the Male Port.

The island nation's decision to renege on its commitment to India comes shortly after Muizzu lauded India's role in the Greater Male Connectivity Project (GMCP), which links Male with the industrial hub of Thilafushi. GMCP is the largest infrastructure project undertaken in the Maldives.

India has undertaken several infrastructure projects in the Maldives over the past eight years, benefiting several thousand Maldivians.

Poliloquy R PRASAD

Masked men vandalise TMC office in Kol.



Cowardly act! We never wore masks in our day!

Terrorist Killed in J&K Encounter; Op Continues

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: A militant was killed in the forest area of Budgam in central Kashmir during an operation on Friday, the armed forces said.

Based on specific intelligence inputs, a joint search operation was launched by the Army, J&K Police and CRPF in the Ashdar Gali, also known as Ashtar Gali, area in the upper reaches of Budgam, officials said.

"Vigilant troops observed suspicious activity and upon being challenged, terrorists opened fire, prompting a fierce exchange of gunfire during which one terrorist was neutralised and one AK rifle and other war-like stores recovered. Search operation is in progress," Indian Army's Srinagar-based Chinार Corps said in a statement. The identity of the slain militant is yet to be established and will be confirmed after forensic examination, officials said.

Security forces are searching for another suspected infiltrator believed to be holed up in the area.

"We have been following this lead for several days now and this particular operation started on Thursday when the contact was established with the terrorists and 10 Para in Ashtar, Dudhpathri area of Khanshab in Budgam," said an official.

PREPARATORY MEETING Four countries push for concrete initiatives on security, technology, emergency response

Quad Sherpas Meet Ahead of Mins' Talk in Oct

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Foreign secretary Vikram Misri hosted a meeting of Quad Sherpas in New Delhi to prepare for the grouping's foreign ministers' meeting in Australia in October, the ministry of external affairs said on Thursday.

The discussions covered key areas of Quad cooperation, including maritime and transnational security, economic prosperity and security, critical and emerging technologies, and humanitarian assistance and emergency response, the ministry said.

The four Sherpas also exchanged views on developments in the Indo-Pacific and the broader regional and global context.

The Sherpas reaffirmed the importance of focusing on concrete, action-oriented initiatives. The meeting was convened to take forward the outcomes of the Quad foreign ministers' meeting held in New Delhi on May 26.

Australia's deputy secretary,



Strategic Planning and Coordination Group, Department of Foreign Affairs and Trade, Elly Lawson; Japan's senior deputy minister for foreign affairs Hiroyuki Namazu; and US ambassador to India Sergio Gorrer attended the meeting.

At their last meeting in Manila on the sidelines of an Asean meeting, the Quad foreign ministers backed the practical implementation of the Asean Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP), seeking

greater regional support for the grouping's efforts to ensure a stable Indo-Pacific.

At the May meeting in New Delhi, the Quad foreign ministers also announced plans to convene an Indo-Pacific Energy Security initiative involving strategic crude oil reserves and emergency response measures, as countries including some Quad members face energy supply-chain disruptions due to the war in West Asia.

ON BECOMING ITALY'S LONGEST CONTINUOUSLY SERVING PM Modi Congratulates Meloni, She Thanks him



NEW DELHI: Prime Minister Narendra Modi congratulated his Italian counterpart Giorgia Meloni on Friday as she became Italy's longest continuously serving postwar PM, calling the historic feat a clear sign of the Italian people's trust and confidence in her leadership. Thanking Modi, Meloni said the relationship between Italy and India is stronger than ever today and together the two

countries continue to strengthen the bond between Europe and Asia as well, working side by side to also develop the India-Middle East-Europe Economic Corridor. Meloni, 49, has been Italy's prime minister since October 22, 2022. On Thursday, after 1,413 days in office, she became the country's longest-serving uninterrupted prime minister since World War II. She is also the first woman to hold the position. —PTI

Heavy Rainfall Disrupts Normal Life, Delhi-NCR Hit by Waterlogging

NEW DELHI: Parts of northern India witnessed heavy rainfall on Friday, with the India Meteorological Department forecasting light to moderate showers over the next few days. In the NCR region, several roads in Delhi and Gurugram were inundated, leading to traffic snarls at prominent places. In the national capital, heavy waterlogging near the Indira Gandhi International Airport disrupted flight operations. —PTI



PHOTO JUNCTION



Mirwaiz Again Prevented From Addressing Jama Masjid on Friday

Hakeem Irfan Rashid

Srinagar: Mirwaiz Umar Farooq was once again prevented from addressing the Friday congregation at the Jama Masjid in Srinagar, a decision he described as punishment for voicing people's concerns.

The Hurriyat leader, who is also the head cleric of Kashmir and heads the Muttahida Majlis-e-Ulema, a grouping of about 50 religious organisations across Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh, also said that separatist leader and former militant Yasin Malik's submission before the court deciding not to contest the case while maintaining his innocence called for serious reflection on commitments made to him.

"The policy to silence the pulpit of Jama Masjid and punish me from voicing people's concerns and standing up in defence of their rights and for justice continues unabated. I am again put under house arrest today on a Friday, when I was also to preside over a function in connection with the blessed Islamic month of Rabi ul Awwal at Jama Masjid in Srinagar," said the Mirwaiz.

Eco Growth & Quality of Life Must go Hand in Hand: Goyal

Commerce & industry minister urges India Inc to expand social-impact programmes

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Real inclusion is the only way to achieve Viksit Bharat by 2047, commerce and industry minister Piyush Goyal said on Friday, calling for a scale-up of social-impact programmes to ensure all people can be covered. Speaking at the Times of India Social Impact Summit in Mumbai, Goyal noted that companies are increasingly spending beyond the mandated 2% of their profits on corporate social responsibility (CSR). “A society cannot develop just if the focus is on the economic aspects of society or economic growth. It has to be juxtaposed with the quality of life that is being provided to the people of India,” the minister said, adding that government schemes on healthcare, housing, sanitation and power supply are aimed at economic growth as well as better quality of life for citizens. And “we are seeing the results of it,” he said. “When you give 40 million people a good, proper home, you are not just giving him a home, you are giving his children good upbringing, you are giving him

dignity.” Goyal cited the government’s health insurance initiative, which helped people avoid situations where hospital bills forced them to sell jewellery, assets or take loans. Similarly, building toilets provided dignity to women besides addressing health concerns due to open defecation, he said. The minister, however, said he felt that the mandatory CSR spending requirement under Companies Act was a “diservice to the Indian ethos, way of life, and Indian thinking, because in India, people don’t do CSR out of compulsion” when it was made mandatory in 2014. “Every person in India voluntarily wants to give back to society, small or big, immaterial,” he reasoned. “The moment we bring it into the garb of compulsion, we change that connection, that motivation to a compulsion. But... hopefully, it has brought more funds into CSR.” There are limitless possibilities to have

social impact and to be change makers when foundations, multinational firms and startups work together, Goyal said. He gave the example of individuals having cleaned up Juhu beach better than any government project and the initiative taken in his constituency to build sewa kendras, toilet complexes which offered shower, soap, laundry and RO water at ₹1 a litre. Stressing the need to work with the private sector on initiatives such as cleaning lakes, even as maintenance is done by citizens, Goyal sought the help of cement, solar power and water filter companies to expand the initiative.



DOUBLE-ENGINE GOVT CONSTANTLY MAKING EFFORTS FOR THIS: UTTAR PRADESH CM

Mathura, Vrindavan to Get Grand Complexes Like Ayodhya: Yogi

Sanjay Singh

New Delhi: Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath on Friday said his government plans to develop big temple complexes in Mathura and Vrindavan on the lines of Kashi and Ayodhya with the support of the Centre. “Our effort is that grand complexes be prepared in Mathura-Vrindavan, just like those of Shri Ayodhya Dham and Kashi,” Adityanath told a gathering of devotees in Mathura on the Janmashtami festival. He alleged that the previous governments were afraid of visiting Shri Krishna Janmabhoomi because they were worried about their vote-bank. “This government has faith in Krishna Kanhaiya, Prabhu Shri

‘DEFAMING AYODHYA’
Today, the world’s grandest temple of Shri Ram is in Ayodhya. Those who don’t like this are defaming Ayodhya: Yogi

Ram, Baba Vishwanath and Ma Vindhya Vasini. But those whose faith lies in Babar and Aurangzeb; can they respect your faith?” the CM said. He first offered his prayers in the temple and then addressed the devotees. Highlighting the construction of “the world’s largest temple” in Ayodhya, Adityanath said the residents of Ayodhya could not imagine that such grand development would ever take place there.

“There were neither roads nor electricity, and there was no adequate water supply. Heaps of garbage were found everywhere. Ayodhya was connected to the railway network by a single line. Devotees who went there would return in tears after witnessing the disorder and chaos,” Adityanath said. “Today, around one lakh devotees visit Ayodhya Dham every day and the figure increases” anywhere between five lakhs to 50 lakhs on special occasions such as Ram Navami, the month of Kartik, Sawan Jhula Mela and Deepotsav. He said there is no inconvenience anywhere and an extraordinary example of social equality is also evident. An international airport has been built in Ayodhya in the name of Maharishi Valmiki, four-lane roads have been constructed from all di-

rections, and the railway line has been doubled, the chief minister said. He said the Sanatan faith continued to grow despite a foreign invader’s attempt to destroy the faith 500 years ago, in 1528. “Those invaders who considered themselves unconquered have no trace left today. They have all disappeared. But our faith was never defeated,” Adityanath said. “Today, the world’s grandest and largest temple of Prabhu Shri Ram has been built in Ayodhya. Those who do not like all this are defaming Ayodhya.” The region, known as Braj Bhoomi, is associated with new enthusiasm, new excitement, and new confidence through events such as Jammotsav, Rangotsav, Brajraj Utsav and Vaishnav Kumbh, Yogi Adityanath also added.

‘Purification’ Row: Congress MPs to Request Meeting with President Murmu

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: Congress members of both Houses of Parliament are planning to request a meeting with President Droupadi Murmu to seek her intervention in the issue of alleged “purification” act at the Haldwani Ramnagar Ground, after party president Mallikarjun Kharge addressed a rally there, people aware of the matter said. Following the leadership’s decision, Congress representatives on Friday

ding a letter to the President, seeking an early date for the MPs, including the Gandhis, to meet her: Condemning the alleged incident as an act of “practising untouchability”, the Congress leadership has been seeking the filing of an FIR against the guilty Kharge, who is also the leader of the Opposition in the Rajya Sabha, on Thursday wrote to House leader JP Nadda, flagging a “delay” in taking action and indicated writing a letter to the Rajya Sabha chairman as well. Earlier, party leader Rahul Gandhi called upon the Prime Minister to order the filing of an FIR against those who did the “purification”.



Calling the act ‘practising untouchability’, Congress has been seeking the filing of an FIR against the guilty



Kumar Anshuman

New Delhi: BJP general secretary Vinod Tawde is set to visit Uttar Pradesh on Saturday, marking his first trip to the state since being appointed the party’s in-charge of UP. For his two-day visit, Tawde has instructed party leaders and workers to avoid an ostentatious welcome, posters and road shows. He has sent out a message that the focus should be on work ahead of assembly elections. The instruction has become a point of discussion as a few days ago, another BJP general secretary, Harish Dwivedi, was accorded a grand welcome by the state leaders on his arrival in Lucknow.

AFTER PENGUIN RANDOM HOUSE INDIA ROW

HarperCollins to Publish Sonia Gandhi’s Memoir in India on November 10

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: HarperCollins India on Friday announced it will publish Congress leader Sonia Gandhi’s memoir, ‘Belonging: A Journey of Love’, in India on November 10. “One of the most anticipated political memoirs of our time, Belonging is a dramatic and deeply personal story of love, identity, duty and belonging, and offers a rare insider’s view of India’s journey,” the publisher said. The development came close on the heels of a row over Penguin Random House India deciding not to publish the book in India following reported differences over certain draft contents. Last month, Alfred A. Knopf announced it would publish



Gandhi’s memoir globally on the same day. The book has evoked much curiosity given that the 79-year-old Gandhi, currently the chairperson of Congress Parliamentary Party, has been in the thick of India politics ever since she became the party president in 1998.

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DJ Ban During Festivals Puts BJP, VHP on Opposite Sides in Maha

Krishna Kumar

Mumbai: A controversy over bans on loud DJs during festivals like Janmashtami and the upcoming Ganesh Utsav has divided the ruling BJP and VHP, sparked violence against those seeking a ban, and drawn interventions from Maharashtra CM Devendra Fadnavis and NCP(SP) chief Sharad Pawar. This comes even as local party leaders openly vow to defy the restrictions imposed by the administration. Pune resident Vidyannand Bapat has been clamouring for a ban on DJs during Ganesh Utsav and other festivals in Pune, claiming that the high-decibel levels are inconveniencing locals.



What Bapat is saying has substance. In a democracy, beating up someone for his views is wrong: Pawar

On Thursday, Bapat was assaulted in public by an irate member of a Ganesh Utsav mandal, an incident that drew condemnation from across the political spectrum. Pawar said, “Festivals should bring joy. What Bapat is saying about noise pollution has some substance to it. In a democracy, beating up someone for his views is wrong.” Fadnavis has vowed strong action against Bapat’s attacker. “Everyone has the right to express their opinion. Attacking someone for expressing their views is not right,” said the CM.

While the rest of Maharashtra debates the ban, several cities have cracked down on the use of DJs. Nagpur Police Commissioner Vishwas Nangre Patil has announced a ban on DJs during the Janmashtami celebrations, with Nagpur BJP president Dayashankar Tiwari vowing to violate the ban. VHP, which until last year had been vociferously demanding a ban on DJs during Hindu festivals, has now taken an about-turn, with local VHP leader Amol Thakre questioning why only Hindu festivals are being targeted. Meanwhile, Solapur Police Commissioner M Rajkumar has also banned DJs, Dolby systems and powerful laser lights. Similar bans have also been imposed in Bhandara and Sangli.

TWO IRRIGATION MILESTONES CAPTURE TRANSFORMATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH’S LONGEST-SERVING POLITICAL LEADER

CEO CM to Water Man: Naidu’s Long Journey Enters a New Phase

Message from Amaravati is clear: In this innings, TDP chief wants his legacy to flow through water

Our Political Bureau

New Delhi: When N Chandrababu Naidu released water through the Polavaram Left Main Canal on Wednesday, it marked more than the commissioning of another irrigation link. Just days earlier, he had inaugurated the first phase of the Poola Subbaiah Veligonda Project — a project whose foundation stone he had laid more than three decades ago, in March 1996. Two irrigation milestones in one week neatly capture the transformation of Andhra Pradesh’s longest-serving political leader: from the “CEO chief minister” who put Hyderabad on the global technology map to a chief minister increasingly seeking to be remembered as the state’s “Water Man”. Water has, in fact, been a constant in Naidu’s political career, even when technology and investment dominated his image.

FIRST EXPERIMENT

Naidu’s first big experiment was not a mega dam but Kuppam, his political constituency. In the 1990s, he promoted drip irrigation, horticulture and dairy, introducing Israeli drip technology to farmers accustomed to rain-fed agriculture. The system saved an estimated 30-50% of water while improving yields. Sericulture, poultry and dairy followed, turning



FILE PHOTO

WATER POLITICS

But Naidu’s current political pitch is different. It is no longer about announcing individual projects, but about creating a system — completing old projects, repairing existing infrastructure and imposing deadlines. The 2026 Irrigation Calendar exemplifies this approach. Thirty-six priority projects, involving an estimated ₹35,555 crore, have been assigned completion targets between 2026 and December 2028. The emphasis extends beyond big-ticket construction. Under Jala Dhara-Jala Harathi, launched in April, the government has identified more than 82,000 water-conservation works involving tanks, canals, check dams, farm ponds and groundwater recharge. **There is also unfinished business from Naidu’s earlier innings. Veligonda is finally delivering irrigation and drinking water.** Polavaram, which he pushed as a national project, remains the centrepiece of his water strategy. The government says 89% of the works were completed during 2014-19 and 2024-26, with the target of full completion by March 2027.

The numbers matter politically because water has always been Andhra Pradesh’s most difficult development equation — linking agriculture, drought, regional disparities, industry and drinking water. Veligonda inauguration triggered a war of words between the ruling TDP and the Opposition. YSRCP chief Jagan Mohan Reddy accused Naidu of stealing credit. In a post on X, Reddy wrote, “... @ncbn garu, the history of Veligonda is crystal clear: The foundation stone alone was yours. The vision and comprehensive development of the project belonged to YSR garu. The crucial twin tunnels were completed during our government. What you are doing now is simply stealing the credit.” For a leader whose first political reinvention was as India’s original technology-friendly CEO CM, Naidu is reinventing himself as Andhra Pradesh’s “Water Man”. The computer screens of Cyberabad have given way to canals, reservoirs and water calendars. The message from Amaravati is clear: in this innings, Naidu wants his legacy to flow through water.

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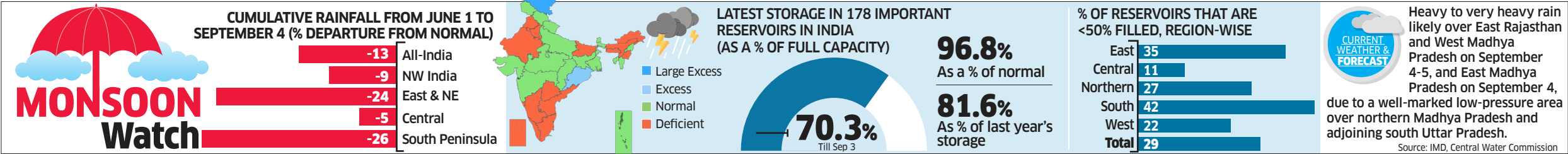
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New FTAs Open Big Export Gains Across Key Sectors

Electronics, agri and gems & jewellery among sectors with biggest opportunities

Kirtika Suneja

New Delhi: Eight new free trade agreements (FTAs) signed in the last five years have opened up duty-free market access of \$982 billion in electronics, \$631 billion in agriculture, and \$442 billion in gems and jewellery for Indian exporters, according to an analysis by the commerce and industry ministry.

Engineering goods, chemicals and pharmaceuticals are the other manufacturing sectors where the market opportunity is high. Two of the trade deals, with New Zealand and the EU, are yet to be operational.

The analysis covered trade pacts with the UK, UAE, Oman, Australia, European Free Trade Association (EFTA) and Mauritius. EFTA comprises Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland. The analysis showed the EU's imported \$6.62 trillion worth of goods in 2024, but India's share was only a meagre 1.23%. The India-EU FTA is expected to come into force next year.

Similarly, the UK's merchandise imports from the world were \$815.6 billion but India's share was only 1.88%. The engineering goods sector offers a whopping \$3 trillion opportunity while labour-intensive sectors such as marine and leather each have a \$70 billion-plus market opportunity in these new markets.

Officials said strong growth across manufacturing, engineering goods, electronics, chemicals, pharmaceuticals, food products and consumer goods has enabled exporters to capitalise on opportu-

Opportunity Galore

Across 8 new FTAs in last five years

Duty-free market access (\$ b)

	Agri	Textile & apparel	Gems & jewellery	Engg goods	Electronics	Pharma
	631	359	442	2,997	982	547

Trade pacts with EU, NZ yet to come into force

Trade deal with US under negotiation

Strong growth in key sectors helps exporters tap trade-deal gains and leverage domestic competitiveness, officials said

nities created by trade deals and expanding domestic competitiveness. "A key feature of the current export performance is the diversification of markets beyond traditional destinations," said an official. "It helps export resilience by reducing dependence on a limited set of destinations and increasing India's participation across multiple regional value chains." The new trade pacts provide 100% duty-free market access to most Indian products of labour intensive sectors, leading to trade expansion. Consider this: India's goods exports to the UAE rose to \$37.3 billion in FY26, from \$28 billion in FY22, buoyed by higher silk, ma-

Significant rise in exports to these countries

	2021-22	2025-26	2021-22	2025-26
Mauritius	0.7	0.5	0.6	0.4
Australia	8.3	7.3	-8.5	-6.5
EFTA	1.7	1.7	-23.7	-23.2
UK	10.5	13.4	3.4	1.8
New Zealand	0.5	0.6	0.1	(-0.02)
EU	65.0	72.4	13.6	6.3
US	76.2	87.3	32.9	33.8
Oman	3.1	4.0	-3.7	-3.1
UAE	28.0	37.3	-16.7	-26.5

Source: Ministry of Commerce and Industry

New RE Units may Need to Store Power for 2 Hours

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The Central Electricity Authority (CEA), under the power ministry, has proposed mandatorily storing energy for at least two hours and equivalent to at least 10% of the installed capacity for new solar and wind projects.

The move brings the needs of utilities and industries to the front by adding storage to renewable energy projects for ensuring firm and continuous power.

According to the draft amendment to the Central Electricity Authority (Technical Standards for Construction of Electric Plants and Electric Lines) Regulations, plants commissioned from July 2027 are required to install the co-located storage. For instance, a 100 MW solar project would need at least 10 MW of co-located storage with a two-hour duration. The comments are to be submitted by October 4.

"While the capex for a renewable energy developer will go up, the project itself should help in predictable dispatch of power which could overall improve the revenues from the project," Sujoy Ghosh, vice president and country managing director, India at First Solar told ET.

The information will be used in the current scrutiny cycle and the next filing cycle, making tax evasion difficult for both companies.

The sweep extends beyond transactions and information reported to the government by multiple agencies and financial intermediaries.

For instance, while data was already shared between GST and the IT department, it was used only in ca-

I-T Expands AIS to Include GST Returns, Overseas Investments

Anuradha Shukla

New Delhi: The Income Tax Department is broadening the scope of financial information required for taxpayers' annual information statements (AIS), bringing goods and services tax (GST) returns, foreign remittances for investment in mutual funds outside banking channels, and off-market securities transactions under the data net.

The department is also allowing relevant information from another taxpayer's income-tax return besides ongoing and completed tax proceedings to get reflected in the AIS.

While data on normal remittances through legal banking channels is already available with the tax department through tax deducted at source (TDS) provision, the additional information will also tap investment in derivative markets and unlisted companies overseas through brokers and overseas agents which used to escape the income-tax net earlier.

The Central Board of Direct Taxes (CBDT) has also authorised the Director General of Income Tax (Systems) to upload this information within three months from the end of the month in which it's received, according to the latest framework being prepared.

"The expanded data pool strengthens the department's ability to match income and transactions declared in tax returns with information generated elsewhere, increasing the possibility of discrepancies being flagged during tax-compliance checks," a senior official told ET.

For investors, AIS can capture off-market transactions reported by depositories or registrars and transfer agents, dividends and mutual fund purchases reported by registrar and transfer agents (RTAs).

"The changes are made on the basis of analysis of tax evasion instances, and with the advanced data analytics

Wider Ambit

Information relating to GST return

Information relating to Specified Financial Transactions (SFT)

Foreign remittance information beyond TDS, TCS via RTAs, tax information exchange

Off Market Transactions Reported by Depository/Registrar and Transfer Agent

Information received from any other person deemed fit in the interest of the revenue

Information relating to pending, completed proceedings

Information received from any officer, authority under an agreement with the tax department

ITR CROSS-MATCH

AIS can now include relevant information from another taxpayer's ITR, strengthening cross-checks of income and transactions

taxpayer's return into the information trail of another taxpayer. In the last three years, the department has widely expanded the data pool that goes into AIS, strengthening its ability to match income and transactions declared in tax returns with information generated elsewhere, increasing the possibility of discrepancies being flagged during tax compliance checks.

This year, the department has included information regarding foreign income for filing returns.

Taxpayers will get a chance to contest information, if they find it incorrect. The income tax portal already allows taxpayers to view AIS through website or taxpayer mobile application and submit feedback if an entry is incorrect or duplicated.

Responses can also be submitted through the department's offline utility.

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Tender Notice No. RWF/S/P2/15/ 2026-27 dtd 03/09/26

On behalf of the President of India, Principal Chief Materials Manager invites Global E-Tender from OEM/Authorised agents for supply of the following items on Indian Railways e-portal www.ireps.gov.in.

- Tender No :** P2265655, **Description :** Design, Supply, installation & commissioning of Primary Fume Extraction System 1 & II of EAF A & B on turnkey basis as per technical specification (Qty - 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 05.10.26 @ 14:00 Hrs. **Pre Bid Conference :** 16.09.26 @ 11:00 Hrs.
- Tender Number :** P2265723, **Description :** Supply, installation, commissioning, testing and proving of Automated Motorized Stage Inverted Metallurgical Microscope with Image Analysis Software with all standard, essential & concomitant accessories, consumables, spare parts along with sample Preparation Equipments and CAMC for 5 years as per Technical Specification (Qty - 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 01.10.26 @ 14:00 Hrs.
- Tender No. :** P2265867, **Description:** Provision of CCTV Surveillance system in Factory and AMC for 5 years as per Technical Specification (Qty - 1 Set). **Tender closing date & time:** 29.09.26 @ 14:00 Hrs.

Tender details can be viewed on RWF website or E-Portal. Tender documents & corrigendum (if any), will be available on the E-Portal only.

Principal Chief Materials Manager

Customs Portal Aims to Curb Divergent Assessment Practices

Our Bureau

New Delhi: The Central Board of Indirect Taxes and Customs (CBIC) has launched a common digital repository of customs assessment decisions, rulings and advisories, giving importers and customs brokers access to a searchable database, a move aimed at reducing divergent practices across customs formations.

The National Assessment Centre (NAC) Portal is expected to provide greater certainty to industry on how similar products and transactions are being assessed across the country. The move is significant for businesses importing goods that have historically faced differing classifications or valuation approaches at different ports.

A common repository of precedents could allow companies to identify the prevailing assessment position and strengthen their submissions when seeking a particular classification or valuation treatment.

Importers will be able to search previous decisions and guidance before filing declarations or responding to assessment queries, potentially reducing delays, representations and litigation arising from inconsistent interpretations. The portal, available at naccustoms.gov.in, brings together Customs Authority for Advance Rulings (CAAR) rulings, legal decisions, audit objections, NAC advisories and alerts, as well as information on classification, valuation and other assessment-related issues. The initiative is the latest step in the customs reforms to

promote uniformity and consistency in customs assessment. "This would promote better compliance, reduce avoidable divergent interpretations and practices, and provide greater transparency and certainty to trade," the CBIC said in a circular issued on Friday. At the same time, the portal is intended to provide a common reference base for assessment decisions, helping prevent repeated examination of issues that have already been settled or considered by another formation.

AI Fuels Low-value Cybercrimes Over High-value Scams

Fraudsters switch to targeting people instead of systems, amid digital boom

Prachi Verma & Pratishtha Bagai

New Delhi: The booming digital economy and rapid spread of AI are fueling low-value cybercrimes rather than high-value scams, with fraudsters switching to targeting people instead of systems and increasingly employing "salami slicing" tactics to evade detection.

A salami slicing strategy refers to a series of incremental steps that are individually too small to trigger a strong response. "Many times, fraudsters attempt to adopt a "salami slicing" approach. So, even though individual financial fraud is not of large value, it is carried out at scale," said Atul Gupta, partner, KPMG, who also leads cyber security services. Among the most widespread frauds nowadays is the fake electricity or gas supply scam, with perpetrators impersonating energy providers and threatening to shut off the power or gas supply unless they are paid immediately. "These scams are currently prevalent in the country and nor-

mally entail very insignificant amounts," said Gupta.

Other common frauds include fake investment offers, account takeovers, spoofed calls, fraudulent payment requests and AI-generated voice or video impersonation, according to experts.

In 2025, 35% of the cases accounted for 76% of the overall money lost in cybercrimes in India, showed Union home affairs ministry data. "This gap is telling. It suggests criminals are now investing in trust-building the same way a legitimate advisor would, which is exactly what makes it harder for victims to spot them," said Akshay Garkel, partner and leader-cyber, Grant Thornton Bharat. More cases with flat-to-lower total losses reflect that the average ticket size per victim is shrinking, consistent with an increase in smaller frauds, said Garkel.

EVENTS AND EXHIBITIONS

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IFT No-KMF/PUR/CFRM-690/2026-27 Dated: 03-09-2026

SHORT TERM TENDER NOTIFICATION (KPPP Tender No.KMF/2026-27/IND2500)

The Karnataka Milk Federation, invites Tenders from eligible Tenderers for supply of following Raw Materials as stipulated below. Tender documents along with EMD details may be downloaded from Karnataka public procurement portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in> Interested tenderers participate in the tender by logging on the website www.kppp.karnataka.gov.in and also may contact KPPP Help line No:080-46010000/080-68948777. any corrections related to the tender will be published on the KPPP portal itself.

Sl. No.	Raw Materials	Cattle Feed Plantwise Requirement in MTs				
		Rajanukunte	Gubbi	Dharwad	Hassan	Shikaripura
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2	Magnesium Oxide	60	30	35	60	0
3	Copper Sulphate	0	0	0	5.5	0
4	Zinc Sulphate	80	30	5	11.5	0
5	Cobalt Sulphate	0	0	0	0.3	0
6	Ferrous Sulphate	0	0	0	5	0
7	Sodium Thio Sulphate	0	0	0	14	0
8	Copper Glycinate	8	0	2.5	1.5	1.5
9	Zinc Glycinate	70	20	0	30	5.5
10	Potassium Iodide	0.6	0.3	0.25	0.5	0
11	Chromium Chelate	0.6	0	0.3	0.1	0.075
12	Lacto Vanilla	0	0	0.05	0.1	0.025
13	Live Yeast Culture	0	0	0	4	0
14	Vitamin E	0	0	0	0.2	0
15	Sodium Bi Carbonate	0	0	0	85	0
16	Sucram	0	0	0	0.35	0

Tender Schedule: Date of Commencement of Tender: 04-09-2026; Pre Bid Meeting: 15-09-2026 at 11.30AM; Last date for submission of Tender: 21-09-2026 at 05.00PM; Date of opening Technical Tender:22-09-2026 at 05.15PM; Date of opening Commercial Tender: 23-09-2026 at 10.15AM.

For KARNATAKA MILK FEDERATION LTD, Sd/- DIRECTOR (PURCHASE).

DeepSeek Plans Big Huawei AI Chip Order to Power New Data Centre

Bloomberg

DeepSeek plans to deploy at least 160,000 of Huawei Technologies's top accelerators at a massive data centre it's building in Inner Mongolia, which could create one of the largest known clusters of Huawei AI chips and advance China's efforts to replace Nvidia.

The AI pioneer intends to use Huawei's next-generation Ascend 950DT chips for operating its models, though the timeline for installation will depend on Huawei's production capabilities, according to people familiar with the matter. The startup doesn't currently plan to use the 950DT chips for training, one of the people said, even though Huawei designed and marketed these processors to serve that more demanding function. While DeepSeek tried to train in its previous models on Huawei chips, it has so far relied on Nvidia

GOING FORWARD

Co intends to use Huawei's next-generation Ascend 950DT chips for operating its models

accelerators for this crucial step.

DeepSeek wants to purchase more of Huawei's best chips, according to the people, but China's semiconductor champion doesn't currently have the production capacity. Shortages of components such as top-end memory will cap Huawei's output of the 950DT at the low hundreds-of-thousands this year, one of the people said. Huawei is balancing demand from other clients and trying to export small volumes overseas, so fulfilling DeepSeek's order could take more than a year, the people said, speaking on condition of anonymity to discuss a confidential deal.

If completed as envisioned, the Inner Mongolia hub will be key to driving AI development at DeepSeek, which is in talks to raise billions of dollars to build out its infrastructure. The installation would dwarf other publicly known clusters of Huawei's Ascend processors, a meaningful step as China tries to wean itself off Nvidia components. By the time it comes online, according to one person with knowledge of Huawei's production capabilities, China could have several clusters of that size.

DeepSeek did not respond to requests for comment.

Eyes on Power Transfer Unit

►► From Page 1

The airline has also started voluntary testing of all its pilots and said it has "zero tolerance" for any breach of safety, fitness or regulatory requirements.

The three hydraulic systems, which operate independently, lost pressure within seconds while the aircraft was in cruise. Aviation safety expert Captain John Cox, president and CEO of Safety Operating Systems LLC and a former A320 captain, said the simultaneous failure was highly unusual.

"The remote idea that three hydraulic systems are going to fail simultaneously goes against everything I know about how airliners are designed and built," he said.

The aircraft detected a loss of the green hydraulic system at 04:02:43 UTC (9:32 am IST), followed four seconds later by that of the blue and yellow systems. The autopilot disengaged, a continuous repetitive chime sounded and a stall warning followed for two seconds.

The co-pilot, who was flying the aircraft, initially responded before the pilot-in-command took control. The aircraft climbed 372 feet above its assigned altitude and then fell 292 feet.

The blue hydraulic system recovered first, followed within seconds by the yellow and green systems, after which the flight-control surfaces recovered and normal operation resumed.

David Soucie, a former US Federal Aviation Administration (FAA) safety inspector, said investigators need to establish what could have affected three normally independent systems within seconds and then allowed all three to recover. "I would want to determine whether we experienced three genuine pressure losses or whether there was a common electrical, sensing, control or indication event," he said.

The aircraft had been dispatched from Phuket with a Minimum Equipment List item relating to its Power Transfer Unit, which had been invoked on July 28. The investigation has not established whether the PTU issue was connected to the hydraulic failure. Soucie said investigators should also examine the aircraft's maintenance history and the deferred PTU.

The aircraft sustained damage to overhead bins, ceiling panels, handrails and other cabin components.

Both pilots passed their post-flight, breath-analyser tests. The pilot-in-command's psychoactive-substance screening test was non-negative, as was the confirmatory blood test. The co-pilot tested negative for both.

POST-MONEY IPO VALUATION UP 5X FROM LAST PRIVATE ROUND

Rentomojo Set to Go Public at ₹4,246 crore Valuation

Rental startup plans to raise ₹1,256 crore through a fresh issue and offer for sale

Disha Acharya & Tanishka Dubey

Bengaluru | Mumbai: Furniture and home electronics rental startup Rentomojo is seeking a valuation of about ₹4,246 crore as it prepares to launch its initial public offering (IPO) next week. The valuation is based on the upper end of the ₹384-404 per share price band it announced last week and is nearly five times higher than its ₹850-900 crore valuation from a private funding round in 2024.

The Bengaluru-based company is raising ₹150 crore in fresh capital, while its investors, including Accel, Chiratae Ventures and ValueQuest, are selling shares worth ₹1,106 crore under offer for sale (OFS). This brings the total issue size to about ₹1,256 crore.

Rentomojo's IPO will open for subscription on September 9 and close on September 11.

Early investors in the company, including Accel and Chiratae Ventures, are sitting on significant paper gains of up to 8.6X and almost 5X after the furniture and

BACK IN ACTION			
Shareholder / Investor	Current stake worth (₹ crore)*	OFS proceeds (₹ crore)*	Return on investment
Geetansh Bamania*	602	34	NA
Accel	857	317	8.6x
Edelweiss	431	116	5.4x
Chiratae Ventures	204	194	4.9x
ValueQuest	365	109	5.3x
Madison India Capital	272	97	7.2x
Note: *Founder *At ₹404 per share Source: Rentomojo RHP			

appliances rental platform set the upper end of its price band at ₹404 per share for its upcoming IPO.

Paper gains refer to unrealised capital gains existing shareholders hold before they sell their

stake to the public after the company is listed.

As part of OFS, Accel could make up to ₹317 crore and Chiratae Ventures could make up to ₹197 crore. Other investors, such as Madison India Capital, could ma-

ke 7.2X returns, or ₹97 crore.

At the upper end of the price band, Rentomojo's founder and promoter, Geetansh Bamania, holds a 14.7% stake in the company worth ₹602 crore. He is selling up to 849,175 shares, or about a 0.8% stake, and is expected to realise roughly ₹34 crore from the OFS.

"The business is now in its fourth year of profitability. We don't need to raise large amounts of primary capital," he said, adding that key shareholders including Accel, Edelweiss, Chiratae and ValueQuest will continue to own meaningful stakes after the IPO.

FY26 EARNINGS

In FY26, Rentomojo's net profit surged nearly 142% to ₹104.3 crore, up from ₹43 crore in the previous fiscal, largely on account of a one-time deferred tax credit of ₹36.6 crore in the previous fiscal year. Its operating revenue grew 45.5% to ₹387 crore in FY26 from ₹266 crore in FY25, driven by addition of new subscribers. Including other income of ₹7 crore, the company's total income for FY26 stood at ₹394 crore.

Smart Ring Maker Oura Files for US IPO as Revenue Surges

Bloomberg

Health and fitness ring-maker Oura filed for an initial public offering, showing soaring revenue as well as increasing losses.

The maker of smart rings that track health, fitness and sleep had a net loss attributable to stockholders of \$924.3 million on revenue of \$1.21 billion for the nine months ended June 30, compared with a net loss of \$182.8 million on revenue of \$697.6 million in the corresponding period a year earlier, according to its filing on Thursday with the US Securities and Exchange Commission. The losses include the effect of a deemed dividend to certain holders of redeemable convertible preferred stock, the filing shows.

Anthropic Finalising \$15b Pre-IPO Credit Facility

Claude maker eyes a blockbuster IPO that could rival SpaceX's debut

Bloomberg

Anthropic is set to finalise expanding its revolving credit facility to \$15 billion, according to people familiar with the matter, clearing a hurdle before the artificial intelligence firm's public filing for its highly anticipated IPO.

Morgan Stanley is leading the process, the people said. Goldman Sachs Group and JPMorgan Chase & Co also have prominent roles on the facility, along with Citigroup, they said. The four lenders are also leading the IPO, Bloomberg News has reported.

The Claude chatbot maker is seeking to raise as much as SpaceX or more in the initial public offering, people familiar with the



preparations have said. Companies typically finalise the revolver before they notify banks of their formal roles in a listing.

Barclays and Wells Fargo & Co. are also expected to have key roles on the loan, the people said. Bank of America, Deutsche Bank AG, Royal Bank of Canada,

and UBS Group AG are also high in the credit facility's lineup, they said.

Generally, in syndicated loans, the higher the commitment of a bank, the higher the fees it gets paid by a borrower. When a large capital markets transaction is expected, a higher ranking in a loan is likely to correspond to a more active role in the upcoming deal.

Bank of Montreal, BNP Paribas SA, Credit Agricole SA, Mizuho Financial Group, Mitsubishi UFJ Financial Group, Sumitomo Mitsui Financial Group and Toronto-Dominion Bank are also on the so-called revolver, the people said.

The credit facility would exceed the company's roughly \$10 billion target, Bloomberg News reported in August.

Isro Puts Advanced Earth-Observation Satellite Into Orbit

EOS-05 to provide near-real-time imagery for agriculture, disaster management & strategic needs

Our Bureau

Bengaluru: The Indian Space Research Organisation (Isro) on Friday successfully launched the 2,367kg EOS-05 Earth-observation satellite aboard the GSLV-F17 launch vehicle from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre in Sriharikota at 2.55 am.

The satellite was injected into its planned sub-geosynchronous transfer orbit about 18 minutes after liftoff. It is expected to be raised to an altitude of around 36,000km, where it will operate in geostationary orbit and match the Earth's rotation.

EOS-05 is described as India's first dedicated geostationary Earth-observation satellite. It is designed to provide near-real-time, multi-band imagery for applications including agriculture, disaster management and strategic national requirements.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi described the launch as "yet another outstanding achievement by Isro." "The successful launch is a reflection of the innovation and growing capabilities that define India's space sector," he said.

"The growing partnership between Isro and Indian industry is adding new strength and scale to our space programme and expanding India's capabilities across the entire space ecosystem," Modi added.

Isro chairman V Narayanan said improvements in the GSLV's structural design and propulsion systems had enabled the vehicle to carry increasingly heavier payloads.

Project Director (Satellite) Imteyaz Ahamed described EOS-05 as a unique, one-of-a-kind satellite with multi-band capabilities. He said its configuration, payload and capabilities made it a complex spacecraft.

Mission director Thomas Kurien said EOS-05 had been uniquely configured for near-real-time imaging. He added that it was the hea-



Indian Space Research Organisation's GSLV-F17 rocket carrying EOS-05 satellite lifts off from the Satish Dhawan Space Centre, in Sriharikota on Friday. PTI

viest satellite launched by the GSLV into a geostationary transfer orbit or sub-GTO.

The mission carried the heaviest payload ever launched by a GSLV, exceeding 2,300kg. Narayanan said the satellite had been precisely injected into the required orbit, its solar panels had deployed successfully, and its systems were functioning normally.

Asked about the satellite's operational life, Narayanan said, "I am confident it will work for more than nine years."

Orbit-raising manoeuvres will subsequently place the satellite in its operational geostationary position.

"This mission is very important for our country because, for the first time, we are going to place an Earth observation satellite in geosynchronous orbit, which is essentially required for continuously monitoring India and its nearby places for Earth observation," Narayanan said.

"Actually, this financial year, we are targeting six more launches. And we are planning to have the navigation satellite launch, NVS-03. Then, of course, we all are working for the Gaganyaan uncrewed vehicle. That is also targeted this calendar year," he said. "Gaganyaan, as you are aware, is a technology-intensive mission. So, we have to do the human-rating of the vehicle, and then the development of the crew escape system, development of the mandrel control system. And till today, around 8,000 tests have been completed," he said.

NARENDRA MODI
Prime Minister

The successful launch is a reflection of the innovation and growing capabilities that define India's space sector

Expansion Beyond Metros

►► From Page 1

"The company got to know about it sometime in April, following which Arora and a few others were asked to leave with immediate effect," the person said.

PVR INOX did not respond to questions sent by ET. WhatsApp messages sent to Pramod Arora were not answered until the publication of this report. ET could not independently establish the identities of the developers allegedly involved in the kickbacks scandal.

As part of the PVR INOX merger contract, Ajay Bijli is responsible for running the company for the first five years starting March 2022, when the union was announced. Arora played a key role in PVR's expansion into Tier II and Tier III markets through asset-light formats, including franchisee-owned, company-operated (FOCO) cinemas and the SMART/Smart Screen initiative. These formats offer lower-priced, digital-first multiplexes aimed at value-conscious audiences in smaller towns.

PVR INOX, India's largest multiplex chain, was created through the 2023 merger of PVR and INOX Leisure. As of late August, it operated 1,786 screens across 356 properties in 113 cities in India and Sri Lanka. The company plans to add another 1,000 screens over the

next five years, largely through franchise-led expansion. The allegations come as PVR INOX's financial performance has improved. The company reported consolidated net profit of ₹56.5 crore in the April-June quarter of FY27, compared with a loss of ₹54.5 crore a year earlier. Revenue from operations rose 11.9% year-on-year to ₹1,622.2 crore, while EBITDA increased 30.8% to ₹528 crore.

Its EBITDA margin expanded to 32.5%, helped by higher occupancy, a stronger film slate and increased contributions from advertising and food and beverage.

PVR INOX had net cash of ₹80.7 crore at the end of the quarter. Its board has also approved a ₹300-crore share buyback at ₹1,450 a share. Promoters hold about 27.5% in the company, with the remaining stake held by foreign investors, domestic institutions and public shareholders. According to a declaration signed by Arora, he was restricted from joining rival cinema chains and from contacting PVR INOX's existing vendors. The declaration provides for potential legal action in the event of a breach.

(With inputs from Javed Farooqui & Rajesh Naidu in Mumbai)

'Bull Run on Beer'

►► From Page 1

"The first quarter of this fiscal, which is the peak season for beer, has been good for the industry. Beer sales have grown by over 17% nationally over the same period last year. July trends too are not different," said Vinod Giri of the Brewers Association of India, which represents United Breweries, AB InBev and Carlsberg.

"This has ridden mainly on favourable excise policy interventions encouraging milder alcoholic beverages in many states," Giri said. Beer sales in Maharashtra and Karnataka have expanded 42% and 35%, respectively, he said. The strong growth comes even as the industry continues to face pressure on profitability. Kartikeya Sharma, president of AB InBev India, said Maharashtra "started the bull run on beer" after the state increased taxes on spirits.

"Maharashtra grew about 40-45% last year, even year to date it's growing 40%," Sharma said. Karnataka has since joined the trend, with beer growing more than 50% over the past three months, he said. "Karnataka jumped onto the bandwagon with probably the most pivotal policy written that I think in history books would be the time beer took off from an inflection point with this alcohol and bottle policy," Sharma said. Sharma said stronger beer sales were spread across several markets, with Telangana showing healthy growth after a decline last year. Bengal, Haryana and Uttar Pradesh were more subdued.

LAGER LOVERS

Brewers also pointed to unusually dry conditions in August as a factor supporting beer consumption. "So now we just need to

hold on to this momentum and it could be one of the better single year industry growth that the category has seen in a very long time," he said.

The pressure on spirits is particularly significant because India's alcohol market remains heavily skewed toward lower-priced products. The country has more than 1.4 billion people, but its drinking population is estimated at around 300 million, with nearly half consuming low-cost or unbranded liquor. The mass-premium segment, once a key growth driver for whisky, rum and brandy, has come under pressure from rising costs and local competition. For fiscal

UNDER PRESSURE

Mass-premium segment, once a key growth driver for whisky, rum and brandy, has come under pressure from rising costs

2025, spirits and beer volumes grew 4%. The latest quarter, however, shows a widening gap between the two categories as consumers respond to relative prices and state excise policies. "When you then look at IMFL value, whether you're talking about premium or value, mid prestige, upper prestige, lower prestige. I think that's where state by state the conversation changes because in some cases there are excise policy reforms or changes, and that could create a vacuum temporarily," said Neeraj Kumar, India managing director, Suntory.

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A TIMES INTERNET INITIATIVE

Will RIL's Next Big Scoop Melt Market?

Entry into icecream biz taps consumption surge

Reliance Consumer Products, an arm of Mukesh Ambani's diversifying business conglomerate, will enter the ice-cream business, with its own brand, Bombay Creamery. Ambani is known to go up against dominant players in industries, such as oil refining, telecom and even colas. This makes the foray into the icecream business that is led by a dairy farmers' cooperative unusual. Yet, Indian business families have a penchant for building diversified groups. The Ambanis have been outliers in this respect with their focus on a few basic industries where they have integrated vertically. Yet, for a group the size of Reliance must see the merits of expansion into unrelated businesses.

Operating across different industries lowers the risk of specific market downturns. Diversified groups can allocate capital freely to new businesses. Shared resources can bring down operating costs across divisions. On the

flip side, running multiple businesses can affect decision-making timelines. Management bandwidth is spread over a wider canvas and could lead to a loss of focus on core operations. Harnessing separate corporate cultures can reduce business value. Investors tend to value diversified conglomerates less than the sum of their parts. It is often more efficient to diversify an investment portfolio than seek the same results through a conglomerate.

Some degree of corporate diversification can be attributed to India's status as a frontline emerging economy that throws up high growth opportunities across a range of industries. Consumption is an obvious theme in the larger India story and has drawn in some of the biggest business groups. Corporate interest is climbing in segments as disparate as housing, food, entertainment and fashion. India needs its own champions in lifestyle brands, and its business barons are ready for the challenge. The consumer space can yield considerable market shares to local brands that can go toe-to-toe with global ones that dominate the landscape. Icecream is as good a place as any to build a truly international brand from India.

Curing Our Broken, Disturbing Roads

A road is only as good as the system that builds and maintains it. India has specifications for road construction. Too often, the distance between what's prescribed on paper and what gets built is measured in potholes, patchwork and pending repairs. NHAI's move to make AI-based machine control (AI-MC) compulsory for highway projects is welcome. Using sensors, computers and real-time data to ensure every layer is built to specification can bring precision, accountability and consistency to 'street credentials'.

There will be an upfront cost. But if better construction means roads that last longer, need fewer repairs and reduce accidents, the investment can pay for itself. In 2025, 62,122 people died on

NHs. Better-engineered roads can't eliminate accidents. But quality is vital to road safety and comfort. Good roads move trucks more efficiently, and reduce fuel use, travel time and logistics costs. A Transport Corporation of India (TCI)-IIM Kolkata study estimated that poor road conditions, delays and frequent halts cost India \$21.3 bn a year — \$6.6 bn in delays and \$14.7 bn in added fuel consumption.

We tend to measure infra in kilometres of highways and billions of rupees. But development — 'viksit' in today's jargon — is experienced on the road outside one's home, on the street to the market, or en route to school. Roads are among the most visible markers of development. NHAI's embrace of tech should extend to city roads, arterial roads and neighbourhood streets, where potholes, shoddy patchwork, poor drainage and constant digging remain common. We need not just better roads, but a culture of moving away from a 'vendor-tender' culture, and of monitoring roads *before* they become laughable definitions of what city roads should be.



THINK ABOUT IT

Leela – play – drives all creativity, even if the players don't know it

Playcore, Lying at the Heart of Creativity

Human creativity, that serious stuff, is built on the least serious of foundations: play. Strip away the jargon of innovation labs, the solemnity of TED talks and the furrowed brows of venture capitalists, and what remains is the same impulse that drives toddlers to stack blocks, and comedians to deliver punchlines. Playfulness isn't a distraction from creativity but its beating heart. The best innovators are players. They may wear suits, gather patents or Nobel Prizes. But underneath, they are children with expensive toys. Thomas Edison tinkered like a boy with a chemistry set. Picasso doodled like a prankster with a spray can. Even Einstein admitted his theory of relativity was born of 'thought experiments' — a fancy way of saying he played with ideas until they popped up proper.

Play comes in two flavours: frivolous and serious. Frivolous play invents Monopoly, Insta reels and government policy in the form of alliterations. Serious play invents vaccines, space travel and nation states. Without frivolity, creativity becomes sterile, ritualistic, dogmatic. Without seriousness, it can't move beyond silly-hood. Together, they produce the kind of breakthroughs that make life richer, stanger and, yes, profitable. Many innovators deny they are playing. They prefer to call it 'research', 'business' or 'disruption'. But who are they kidding?

We need mandatory, evidence-based front-of-pack labels consumers can understand instantly



Rohit Kumar Singh

Walk into any supermarket and pick up a packet of biscuits, cereal or chips. Front-of-pack labelling (FOPL) is a masterpiece in communication: attractive colours, catchy claims, endorsements, photographs, and promises of health, energy or goodness. But nutritional reality is usually relegated to a small table on the back. That asymmetry needs to change.

The debate over FOPL has gained urgency after an investigative report said that India's efforts to introduce prominent warnings for products high in sugar, salt and fat faced opposition from sections of the food and beverage industry. The industry has since said India should consult companies while framing new FOPL rules.

Industry should be consulted. Manufacturers understand formulations, supply chains, packaging constraints and consumer behaviour, and their inputs can improve implementation. But consultation cannot become a veto. The key purpose of food labelling is not to protect the packet's appearance. It is to protect the consumer's right to make an informed choice.

India is witnessing a rapid nutrition transition. The country continues to deal with under-nutrition while facing an expanding burden of obesity, diabetes, hypertension and cardiovascular disease. Against this background, requiring consumers to decipher percentages, serving sizes, and grams of sugar and mg of sodium from a dense nutrition panel is inadequate.

There is an important distinction between providing information and making information understandable. Existing nutrition tables may satisfy the first test. Effective FOPL satisfies the second. A person buying breakfast cereal should not ne-

Let's Know What We Eat



Sauce for home food is sauce for packaged food

ed a degree in nutrition to work out whether it is unusually high in sugar.

WHO describes FOPL as an important policy tool to help consumers make healthier food choices. It recommends that governments introduce nutrition declarations and supplement them with FOP information that is convenient, relevant and readily understood. It also points to another important benefit: well-designed labelling can encourage manufacturers to reformulate products. That second effect is often underestimated.

The biggest benefit of a strong labelling regime may eventually come not from consumers rejecting products but from manufacturers changing them. If a visible label tells consumers that one product has significantly more sugar or salt than another, competition begins to work in favour of public health. Companies have an incentive to innovate, reduce undesirable ingredients and improve their nutritional profile. The market then becomes part of the solution.

Consistency is also a question. Nestlé says it has implemented Nutri-Score on thousands of products across continental Europe. Nutri-Score uses a simple 5-colour scale from A to E to help consumers compare nutritional quality. Such labelling helps people make informed choices and encourages the company to improve the nutritional value of its products.

This makes the Indian debate difficult to explain. If an easily understandable nutritional label helps consumers in France, Germany or Belgium make informed choices, why should an Indian consumer be expected to manage with less?

This is not an argument for mechanically importing a European system. India's food habits, dietary patterns, literacy levels and market structure are different. We need a system designed for India. The debate should not be reduced to whether India must adopt a particular colour, symbol or scoring methodology. There are legitimate scientific questions around nutrient thresholds and portion sizes, and whether labels should provide warnings or comparative scores. These questions should be settled through evidence.

FSSAI should commission transparent consumer-testing across regions, languages, income groups and education levels. Nutrition scientists, public

health experts, consumer organisations and industry should participate. The scientific basis for thresholds should be published. The selected label should then be simple enough for an ordinary consumer to understand instantly. The final system must also be mandatory.

Voluntary labelling inevitably creates an adverse-selection problem. Companies with healthier products have an incentive to display favourable information. Those with products high in sugar, salt or saturated fat may have precisely the opposite incentive.

A common standard creates a level playing field.

Industry concerns about transition costs are legitimate and can be addressed through reasonable implementation timelines. Smaller manufacturers may require greater flexibility and technical support. Regulation should always be proportionate. But the principle itself should not be compromised.

Indeed, FOPL should not be viewed as anti-industry. India's food-processing sector is one of the country's important growth opportunities. Stronger consumer standards can increase trust, encourage innovation and push Indian companies towards products that can compete globally. Consumers, meanwhile, remain free to choose.

India has spent years strengthening consumer empowerment through better disclosure, digital access and more competitive markets. Food cannot remain an exception. The front of a food package today is some of the most valuable advertising real estate in the consumer economy. Almost every centimetre is carefully designed to influence the purchasing decision.

It is reasonable to reserve a small part of that space for the truth about what is inside. FOP cannot belong entirely to marketing. Some of it must belong to the consumer, too.

It is reasonable to reserve a small part of the front of a food package for the truth about what is inside

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It is reasonable to reserve a small part of that space for the truth about what is inside. FOP cannot belong entirely to marketing. Some of it must belong to the consumer, too.

The writer is former secretary, ministry of consumer affairs, food & public distribution, GoI

Curb Misselling, Not Agents



Sriram Kalyanaraman

Ask anyone who was sold a 'guaranteed wealth-builder' and later tried to escape it. The product was costly, unsuitable and locked shut. That is misselling, and it is not rare. It usually begins with one broken incentive: when a seller earns almost everything from the first sale, the complicated, high-commission policy gets sold rather than the simple one the customer needed.

So, IRDAI's instinct to rethink how intermediaries are paid is sound. The regulator wants lower distribution costs, more policies that stay alive, and better value for buyers. The worry is not the goal. It is whether the fix damages the network that reaches ordinary Indians in the first place.

Two proposals are in play. One spreads the commission across the life of the policy instead of front-loading it. The other ties pay to an agent's 'effort' in sourcing and serving customers. Both are meant to protect the buyer. Both also add complexity to a system

that runs on pay being simple and predictable.

Individual agents still bring in roughly 51% of individual new-business premium. Banks, through bancassurance, account for about 33%, and the rest comes from direct, online and broker channels. Two decades ago, agents wrote nearly 90% of the business, so the shift to banks has been dramatic. LIC remains agent-heavy, while most private insurers lean on their bank partners.

That split matters because the conduct risk is not spread evenly.

► In 2024-25, life insurers sold about 2.70 cr new individual policies, LIC sold 1.78 cr of those, private insurers sold about 92.5 lakh.

► Complaints filed under unfair business practices rose to 26,667, from 23,335 a year earlier — up roughly 14%.

What makes that stand out is the backdrop. Total life complaints barely moved, from 1,20,726 to 1,20,429. The pie stayed the same size while the misselling slice grew from about 19% to 22%. Set 26,667 against 2.70 cr new policies, and it is close to 1 in 1,000.

Although the share is small, the trend is negative and reflects issues with the sale process.

Here are the parts reformers should sit with. Much of the loudest misselling has come from bank counters —



Cherish the network

policies dressed up as FDs or quietly bundled into loans. One hears a lot of misselling in bundled loans. Both FM and IRDAI chief said as much in 2024. Yet, commission reform lands hardest on the individual agent, whose pay is visible and straightforward to cut, not on the bank channel, where the incentive is buried in a wider banking relationship. Squeeze the agent, who is an easier target, and you may leave the bigger problem untouched.

The reforms could also backfire where India can least afford it. Life insurance still reaches under 3% of GDP, and crores of Indians hold no cover at all. That last mile runs on roughly 26 lakh individual agents, most working in small towns and villages where a policy is sold across a kitchen table, not a screen. For them, the upfront commission is working capital — it pays the bus fare, the repeat visits, and the hours spent explaining what a policy does.

Every GW Saved is a GW Earned



Samir Saran & Parul Bakshi

Indian philosophical traditions have long warned against excess without rejecting prosperity. 'Aparigraha', restraint in possession, does not demand denial but calls for mindful use. Reimagined for a modern energy economy, it offers a strategic insight: efficiency is not austerity but disciplined abundance.

As India engages with another season of record electricity demand — with peak power requirement expected to touch 300 GW in 2027 — the policy instinct is familiar: more generation, stronger grids, larger storage, faster transmission. However, in an era shaped by climate extremes and geopolitical uncertainty, how well a nation uses energy may matter as much as how much it produces.

India's rising energy demand is a marker of development. Per-capita electricity consumption climbed to about 1,538 kWh in 2025, and demand is projected to grow a further 6% annually this decade. Cooling demand alone could account for nearly 1/3rd of peak load by 2030, with peak demand rising by more than 7 GW for every additional degree of daily average temperature.

Without major efficiency gains in buildings, appliances and cooling, this risks locking in higher generati-

on needs and deeper grid stress for decades, since what is built today shapes demand for a generation. Efficiency is now a time-critical determinant of whether India's energy future now stays affordable, stable and secure. The strategic question, therefore, is not whether India should consume more energy, but whether each additional unit can contribute more efficiently towards national growth.

Energy efficiency in India is treated as a technical intervention, rather than an instrument of national strategy. Mega-projects command visibility, financing and urgency; efficiency-driven avoided demand is less politically appealing, although even more vital.

Governance remains fragmented across ministries, regulators, utilities and states, with no institutional centre capable of elevating efficiency to core infrastructure. Capital, too, flows far more readily toward generation than efficient consumption, an imbalance increasingly at odds with fuel shocks, supply disruptions, climate-driven demand spikes and accelerating electrification, all redefining energy security.

In such a landscape, the most strategic unit of energy is not the MW newly produced but the MW never required. Saved energy is immediate, domestic and largely immune to geopolitical risk, an instrument of resilience and sovereign power that determines not only how India grows but

how securely it does.

Energy security is often framed through availability, accessibility, affordability and acceptability. Efficiency is one of the few interventions capable of strengthening all 4 at once.

► **Availability** Rapid growth in cooling demand could push ACs alone to account for close to 30% of projected electricity needs. According to some calculations, stronger efficiency standards can help avoid up to 60 GW of peak demand while saving consumers tens of billions of dollars. In effect, efficiency creates new 'virtual capacity' faster and more economically.

► **Accessibility and affordability** Efficient appliances and cooling technologies cut household bills and system-wide costs, while lower peak demand reduces the need for costly backup generation, storage and grid expansion. UJALA illustrates the potential, where more than 36 cr LED bulbs have generated 48 bn kWh in annual savings and cut consumer expenditure by over ₹19,000 cr each year. Acceptability, the climate dimension, follows naturally: meeting cooling and comfort needs with less energy cuts emissions and infrastructure pressure without constraining growth.

► **Acceptability** India has built a broad efficiency policy ecosystem. Programmes such as UJALA LED, the market-based Perform, Achieve and Trade (PAT) scheme, and Standards and Labelling have demonstrated the potential of

demand-side efficiency at scale, while the Energy Conservation Building Code, Eco-Niwas Samhita, and Green Rating for Integrated Habitat Assessment have sought to embed efficiency into the buildings shaping India's urban future. India already has many of the tools. Few strategies improve all 4 pillars of energy security with comparable speed and economic logic. That combination makes efficiency foundational to energy policy, that is forward-looking.

If efficiency is to function as infrastructure rather than aspiration, India must move from dispersed programmes to deliberate strategy, in 3 steps:

- Embed efficiency explicitly within India's energy-security architecture, alongside generation, grids and storage, as a core planning resource.
- Govern the coming wave of urban construction, cooling deployment and digital infrastructure with performance standards that prevent decades of inefficient demand from locking in the system.
- Accelerate market mechanisms, from demand response and utility incentives to scalable financing, so private capital flows toward optimising consumption with the same confidence as new capacity.

Efficiency is not simply a strategic resource. Every unit saved reduces future infrastructure needs, moderates import dependence and strengthens resilience. Making efficiency strategic is an exercise in long-term statecraft. Nations that learn to do more with less will shape the resilience of the 21st-c. energy order.

Saran is president, and Bakshi is fellow, energy and climate, ORF



THE SPEAKING TREE

AI and Teachers

NEIL VIMALKUMAR

With the possibilities thrown open by AI, can human teachers be replaced? While AI can handle surveys, data processing and analysis far more efficiently, a teacher's role may never be completely replaced by a robot. Here is why. Teaching is far more than transferring data from a teacher to a pupil. As we grow more dependent on virtual teaching platforms, we cannot overlook the inevitability of a personal teacher. In many ancient Asian contexts, gurus and shishyas even lived together as life skills and knowledge were imparted to students. So, the teacher knew the subject matter and also lived an exemplary life worthy of emulation. Integrity meant character matched capability.

John Searle's thought experiment in cognitive philosophy highlights the personal component of human discernment against a machine's proficiency. While AI tools can give us correct responses, they would never be able to 'understand' as they would be focused on the syntax of symbols, and not the semantics of the message. A few decades ago, Michael Polanyi, a philosopher of science, pointed out that even in the scientific institution, there is a tradition of knowledge where everything is not just 'impersonal' data. There is an element of trust, personal knowledge, judgement and social context that cannot be ignored. While AI might bring multiple skills and incredible speeds to the table, we need people to lead people.

LOLLING ON SATURDAY

Social Media Addict

A man went to the doctor and said, 'Doctor, I think I'm addicted to social media.'

The doctor frowned. 'How long have you had this problem?'

The man immediately pulled out his phone. 'Let me check.' He scrolled for a while. 'Apparently, someone had this exact problem in 2018.'

Doc: And? Man: He was cured. Doc: How? Man: He deleted all his social media apps. Doc [smiles]: Excellent. You can do the same. Man [horrified]: Doctor, I said I'm addicted. I didn't say I was insane!

Marriage Advice

A newly married man asked his grandfather: 'What's the secret to a happy marriage?' Nanaji: 'Never argue with your wife. Grandson: That sounds impossible! Nanaji: It's not. Whenever she's right, agree with her. Grandson: And when she's wrong? Nanaji [smiles]: She's never wrong. Grandson [sighs]: That's your secret? Nanaji: No. My secret is that I've been married for 62 years. Grandson: Exactly. So you must know something. Nanaji: I know when to keep my mouth shut. Grandson: About what? Nanaji: Everything.

Chat Room

Bring Mammon To the Mountain

Appropos 'Trishuli and China Question for Nepal' by Safi Ahsan Rizvi (Sep 4), Nepal's demand for climate compensation is morally compelling but legally and politically contentious. Despite its negligible contribution to global emissions, Nepal faces disproportionate threats from glacier retreat, floods and landslides. Yet, assigning exclusive responsibility for specific losses to India, China or the US remains scientifically difficult, since natural variability, deforestation, unplanned construction and infrastructural deficiencies can exacerbate disasters. Nepal's stronger case lies in demanding predictable multilateral climate finance, adaptation assistance and loss-and-damage support, rather than seeking potentially unlimited bilateral reparations from individual countries. N Sadhasiva Reddy Bengaluru

VIA GOVT AUCTION

Shalimar Buys Lucknow Land Parcel for Record ₹450 cr

Faizan Haider

New Delhi: Lucknow based real estate developers Shalimar Corp has acquired an around 3-acre land parcel for ₹450 crore in the costliest deal of the city and among the costliest in tier 2 cities.

Developers in tier 2 cities, especially in the capital city, are bullish on acquisition at prime locations with demand for premium housing growing.

In total, 111 land deals spanning around 3,000 acres were inked in FY26, of which 520 acres were acquired in tier 2 cities.

“The time has come for India’s Tier-2 cities to experience another wave of growth in real estate, aided by improved infrastructure, more industries and businesses, as well as home-owners’ ambitions.

Consumers in this market segment are no longer interested only in affordable housing; they now want to live in planned neighbourhoods where they will find quality building, modern amenities, sustainability, and future appreciation,” said Khalid Masood, MD of Shalimar Corp.

The firm has acquired the land through government auction and said that it was one of the last land parcels at a prime location in Lucknow.

In a Nutshell

Zaveri Group's Bid for GHPSL Set Aside by NCLAT

New Delhi: The insolvency appellate tribunal NCLAT has set aside Zaveri Group's resolution plan for Gujarat Hydrocarbons and Power SEZ (GHPSL) and directed the Resolution Professional and NCLT to start the process again by inviting fresh bids. A two-member NCLAT bench observed that the bid submitted by Zaveri & Co was based on an “unverified and contested presumption” that the leasehold of the land owned by the Gujarat Hydrocarbons and Power SEZ (GHPSL) will be de-notified from Special Economic Zone (SEZ) status.

Heavy Rains Hit Flight Ops at Delhi Airport

New Delhi: At least 11 flights were diverted at the Delhi airport on Friday due to bad weather conditions. An official said 5 flights were diverted to Jaipur, 4 flights to Lucknow, and 1 flight each to Ahmedabad and Chandigarh. The diversions happened between 3.30 pm and 5 pm, the official added. Heavy rains lashed various parts of the national capital on Friday afternoon. More than 400 flights were delayed at the Delhi airport on Friday, according to information available on flight tracking website Flightradar24.com.

Honasa Eyes 2-fold Rise in Revenue by FY31

New Delhi: Honasa Consumer, the owner of beauty brand Mamaearth, expects a two-fold rise in its revenue to ₹5,550 crore in the next five years by FY31, said its founders on Friday. The company is also hopeful of its Ebitda margin expanding to 15% during the same period.

Rio to Take Leaf out of Guj’s Green Playbook

Country to adopt Gujarat’s emissions trading model, recognised by Earthshot Prize, to deal with air pollution

Urmi Goswami

New Delhi: Gujarat’s success in bending the industrial pollution curve through the creation and implementation of a particulate emissions market is a case study worth examining. Several states, including Maharashtra, have lined up to follow suit.

Actually, Gujarat’s pioneering emissions trading model has found a taker abroad. This June, at London Climate Week, Rio de Janeiro mayor Eduardo Cavaliere announced plans for the city to take a leaf out of Gujarat’s book and set up a market for pollutants.

The journey from Surat to Rio would not have been possible without collaboration and cooperation. It required

Telco Operators Reject Quality of Service Norms for 5G Slicing

Call for resource utilisation benchmarks to be dropped while advocacy groups want them retained

Our Bureau

New Delhi: Telecom operators such as Reliance Jio, Bharti Airtel, and Vodafone Idea jointly pushed back against the telecom regulator’s draft proposals on quality of service (QoS) norms for commercial 5G network slicing, calling for the proposed resource utilisation benchmarks to be dropped entirely even as public advocacy groups said they can be retained.

In August, the telecom regulatory authority of India (Trai) released draft guidelines for telcos to deploy 5G network slicing-based use-cases to ensure that the dynamic resource allocation technology does not degrade service quality for general subscribers, amidst a debate around net neutrality.

Trai had proposed measuring quality of service by monitoring use of telecom resources in areas where slicing is activated, proposing that radio resources can’t exceed 80% utilisation to ensure there is breathing room when telcos divide the physical resource blocks to deliver specialised services.

Telcos opposed the move entirely arguing that physical resource blocks utilisation is an internal radio-resource and input indicator, rather than a customer-facing quality of service metric. Actual customer

impact is being captured via metrics such as speed and throughput.

In its written comments as part of the stakeholder consultation by the Trai, Bharti Airtel said higher PRB utilisation does not mean poor QoS and setting an arbitrary 80% utilisation ceiling penalises operators for efficiently using scarce spectrum resources. Airtel added that imposing a rigid cell-level threshold will create artificial network constraints on operators, forcing them to prematurely augment capacity and misallocate capital expenditure on cells that are already delivering satisfactory throughput.

Reliance Jio added that the 80%

threshold as a mandatory trigger to suspend network slices is operationally unfeasible. Jio said modern 5G networks employ technologies specifically designed to trigger at high utilisation levels to ensure efficient spectrum utilisation.

Jio also argued that restricting utilisation levels tied to a specific service category, violating spectrum assignment conditions, technology neutrality, and ease of doing business. However, public policy think tanks such as The Dialog agreed with Trai that the proposal of measuring QoS through capacity

utilisation levels benchmark acts as a vital capacity safeguard to prevent slices from degrading the network. However, Trai should also use other means to measure impact.

GSMA argued that PRB utilisation is a useful internal planning indicator, but it should not be used in isolation as a regulatory measure of congestion or QoS. It said high utilisation during a cell’s busiest hour does not prove that users are experiencing poor service, or whether a particular slice caused the load, or immediate capacity augmentation is justified.

Vi opposed imposing such thresholds on cell-level, adding slicing as a tool is meant to be used when resources are constrained. When spare capacity is available, all users access the network at the highest possible throughput, linking slices to a utilisation threshold is technically unjustified.

At Crossroads

ISSUE	TELECOM OPERATORS	THINK-TANKS/PUBLIC GROUPS
80% utilisation cap	Drop it as arbitrary and impractical	Retain it as a network safeguard
PRB* utilisation	Internal indicator, not customer-facing QoS	Useful for monitoring network capacity
High utilisation	Does not necessarily mean poor service	Could signal risks to overall network quality
Operational impact	May restrict spectrum use and increase costs	Provides essential capacity headroom
Network slicing	Threshold-based suspension is technically unworkable	Supports safeguards against service degradation
Speed benchmarks	Minimum speeds cannot be guaranteed wirelessly	Supports minimum speed benchmarks

GPT-6 said to outperform several rival models for coding, cybersecurity, reasoning and more

Astra May Tip Balance in OpenAI’s Favour

Himanshi Lohchab

Mumbai: OpenAI’s latest GPT-6 Astra appears to have raised the bar in the frontier AI model race with its ability to perform complex, multi-step knowledge work on its own across financial modelling, chip design, geospatial mapping, 3D modelling, architecture and software engineering.

Unveiled on Thursday, Astra has outperformed rival models from Anthropic, Google, Meta and Chinese labs Alibaba and Moonshot on key benchmarks for coding, cybersecurity, computer use and reasoning, according to the Sam Altman-led company.

“Anything you can do on a computer, Astra can do for you. Fast,” OpenAI said in its launch video, which demised the model designing a rock

Super Weapon

Trained on 100,000 GPUs at \$1B, it’s one of the costliest models

Advanced capabilities in fin modelling, chip design, 3D modelling, reasoning, gaming

BALANCE OF POWER

IPO valuations

\$2T OpenAI

\$3T Anthropic

PIPS ALL AI MODEL SERIES

Anthropic: Fable, Mythos, Opus

Google: Gemini

Meta: Muse, Spark

SpaceXAI: Grok

Alibaba: Qwen

Moonshot: Kimi

et, creating an eBay listing, building a 3D game, editing a licensing agreement and ordering food—all through simple voice commands.

Some see it as another “ChatGPT moment” for OpenAI as Astra would potentially allow companies to delegate complicated tasks to AI agents, even without any human in-

HUL Bets on Cost Cuts, Brand Push to Revive its Growth: MD

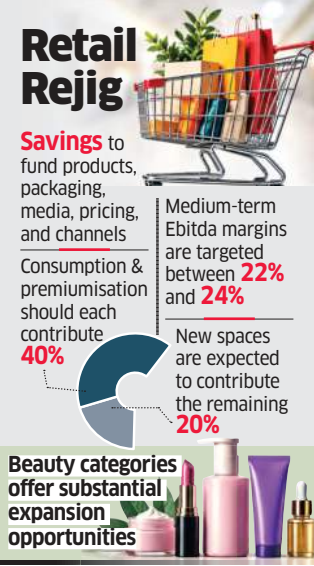
Co to raise capex, position some of its established brands around changing consumer trends: Execs

Aanya Thakur

Mumbai: Hindustan Unilever is looking to revive growth after a muted two-year period marked by cutting costs, sharpening portfolio and putting more money behind brands, distribution and new categories, managing director and chief executive Priya Nair said.

The country’s largest consumer goods company also plans to increase capital expenditure to 3% of turnover from 2%, with more than 75% of that directed towards growth and savings, Nair said at the company’s Capital Markets Day event.

HUL is targeting 500 basis points (5.0 percentage points) of “fuel for growth”, through a combination of improved margins, operating efficiencies and savings, chief financial officer Niranjan Gupta said. It plans to redeploy those gains into the business, including product and packaging, media and sampling, pricing and pack architecture and channel investments.



The maker of Rin and Dove has set itself a medium-term Ebitda margin target of 22-24%. For FY26, the company posted an Ebitda margin of 23.6%.

The plan is to generate savings without relying on cost cuts alone, with HUL also seeking to increase operating leverage as revenue growth outpaces expansion in fixed costs.

Nair’s strategy is built around four growth pools—increasing con-

sumption, premiumisation, bringing more consumers into categories and entering new spaces. HUL expects consumption and premiumisation to each account for 40% of incremental turnover, with new spaces contributing 20%, Nair told investors.

The company, often considered a proxy for consumer demand in India, is also betting on a shift in consumer preferences within its existing portfolio.

In beauty and wellbeing, HUL sees substantial room to expand categories such as bodywash, skin cleansing and functional deodorants, executive director Harman Dhillon said.

The company plans to invest in developing functional deodorants, citing low usage in India and changing lifestyles as an opportunity. HUL is also putting more resources behind premium beauty. More than 60% of its media spending is digital, while investment in premium brands is twice that of non-premium brands.

Stellantis in Talks with Huawei, JAC over Maserati Deal

Reuters

Milan: Automaker Stellantis is in talks with China’s Huawei and JAC Group for long term industrial cooperation on its struggling luxury brand Maserati, two sources told Reuters. Stellantis CEO Antonio Fiolosa said earlier this year that the world’s fourth-largest automaker was working on further manufacturing partnerships, including for Maserati, after such deals emerged as a key pillar of the group’s new long-term strategy. A new deal for Maserati will have a positive impact on production rates at the Cassino and Modena plants in Italy, where the brand’s models are manufactured. Italian daily Milano Fiananza first reported on Friday about ongoing talks between Stellantis, Huawei and JAC Group over Maserati.

FORM A
PUBLIC ANNOUNCEMENT
(Under Regulation 6 of the Insolvency and Bankruptcy Board of India (Insolvency Resolution Process for Corporate Persons) Regulations, 2016)
FOR THE ATTENTION OF THE CREDITORS OF INFILLOOM INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED

RELEVANT PARTICULARS

1. Name of corporate debtor	Infilloom India Private Limited
2. Date of incorporation of corporate debtor	06/10/1995
3. Authority under which corporate debtor is incorporated / registered	RoC – Pune
4. Corporate Identity No. of corporate debtor	U17118PN1995PTC018285
5. Address of the registered office and principal office (if any) of corporate debtor	Gat No. 1231 (Part), Sanaswadi, Taluka Shirur, District Pune, Maharashtra - 412208.
6. Insolvency commencement date in respect of corporate debtor	04/09/2026
7. Estimated date of closure of insolvency resolution process	03/03/2027
8. Name and registration number of the insolvency professional acting as interim resolution professional	Pulkit Gupta IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P-02364/2021-2022/13697
9. Address and e-mail of the interim resolution professional, as registered with the Board	Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 3rd Floor Worldmark 1, IGI Airport-Hospitality District, Aerocity, New Delhi - 110037 Email: pulkit.gupta@in.ey.com
10. Address and e-mail to be used for correspondence with the interim resolution professional	Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 14th Floor, The Ruby, 29 Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400028 Kindly ensure that all claims and claim-related queries are sent only to: E-mail: claims.ipil@gmail.com For any other query please mail to: E-mail: insolvency.ipil@gmail.com
11. Last date for submission of claims	18/09/2026
12. Classes of creditors, if any, under clause (b) of sub-section (6A) of section 21, ascertained by the interim resolution professional	Not Applicable
13. Names of Insolvency Professionals identified to act as Authorised Representative of creditors in a class (Three names for each class)	Not Applicable
14. (a) Relevant Forms and (b) Details of authorized representatives are available at	(a) Web link: https://ibbi.gov.in/home/downloads (b) Not Applicable

Notice is hereby given that the National Company Law Tribunal has ordered the commencement of a corporate insolvency resolution process of Infilloom India Private Limited on September 04, 2026. The creditors of Infilloom India Private Limited are hereby called upon to submit their claims with proof on or before September 18, 2026, to the interim resolution professional at the address mentioned against entry No. 10. The financial creditors shall submit their claims with proof by electronic means only to claims.ipil@gmail.com. All other creditors may submit the claims with proof in person, by post or by electronic means. Submission of false or misleading proofs of claim shall attract penalties.

Sd/-
Pulkit Gupta
Interim Resolution Professional
Reg No: IBBI/IPA-001/IP-P-02364/2021-2022/13697
Registered Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 3rd Floor Worldmark 1, IGI Airport Hospitality District, Aerocity, New Delhi - 110037
Date: September 05, 2026
Place: Mumbai
Correspondence Address: EY Restructuring LLP, 14th Floor, The Ruby, 29 Senapati Bapat Marg, Dadar (West), Mumbai - 400028

IN RELIEF TO HARDWARE MANUFACTURERS...

Govt Floats Fresh IT Tenders at Higher Prices

Subhrojit Mallik

New Delhi: Government departments are adjusting to high prices of IT hardware by floating fresh tenders with 30-40% higher pricing, or procuring fewer units within the same pre-allocated budget. This comes as a relief to manufacturers after some tenders lapsed, with no brands bidding at outdated prices.

Industry executives said many previous state government tenders floated earlier this year at outdated pricing were not finalised as no brands were ready to bid at those prices. For instance, orders placed by state governments of Chhattisgarh and Jharkhand for their respective state police forces were scuttled and as of now, no fresh tenders have been floated yet for these projects.

Others such as the Tamil Nadu government have placed fresh orders of 30,000-40,000 desktop



PCs at updated prices by floating a fresh tender in the June quarter, after scrapping older tenders. Government departments in Gujarat and Uttar Pradesh have also floated fresh tenders reflecting higher prices, executives said.

Acer, one of the largest suppliers to the government, said it has won a ₹2,200 crore deal from the Uttar Pradesh Government to supply 1.25 million 8-inch tablet PCs to students in Uttar Pradesh. Homegrown handset brand Lava International has also won a part of that tender, supplying 25 lakh tablets to students in the state ahead of assembly elections next year, the company confirmed.

DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL - I, KOLKATA
PUBLIC NOTICE FOR SALE OF AIRCRAFT THROUGH E-AUCTION
IDBI BANK LTD VS M/S PATHBREAKING PROJECTS LIMITED (in liquidation)
(Formerly Abhijeet Projects Ltd.) & others OA No.124/2016
Receiver appointed by DEBTS RECOVERY TRIBUNAL-I, Kolkata invites offer through E-auction for purchase on "as is where is basis, as is what is basis, whatever there is basis and without any recourse basis", without any representation, warranty, or indemnity" following aircraft of Pathbreaking Projects Limited.

PROPERTY DESCRIPTION	AIRCRAFT-Model-BOMBARDIER - CHALLENGER-605, Registration-VT MKJ, MSN-5848, Year of manufacture- 2010, Engine- General Electric APU- Honeywell, Manufacturer- Bombardier (presently grounded at Nagpur Airport, Maharashtra)
Reserve Price & EMD amount	Reserve Price: US \$ 29,20,000 (equivalent INR at exchange rate on the day of the sale as provided by IDBI Bank) EMD: US \$ 2,92,000 (equivalent INR at exchange rate on the day of submission of EMD as provided by IDBI Bank)
Minimum Incremental Bid	US \$ 5000/- per bid
Date of Sale Notice	September 05, 2026
Date of Aircraft Inspection	September 18, 2026 (Friday) From 12 pm to 4 pm
Last date of submission of offer along with EMD	October 07, 2026 till 5 pm
Date of e-auction	October 08, 2026
Time of e-auction	1200 hrs. to 1400 hrs. (with unlimited extension of 5 minutes each per IST)

1. The sale would be conducted on e-auction platform at [website: https://www.bankauctions.com](https://www.bankauctions.com) through e-auction service provider **C21 India Pvt. Ltd.**
2. The interested parties may submit their unconditional and unqualified offer along with EMD and other required documents before the last date. On verification of documents and receipt of the EMD, the bidders shall receive user id/password on their valid email id (mandatory for e-auction) from the e-auction service provider for participating in e-auction.
3. Intending bidder may obtain terms and conditions of the sale process from Shri. Basudeb Mukherjee, Advocate/Receiver (M)9830033082 (e-mail) basudebmukherjee@yahoo.in Shri. Durga Prasad Channapati, Deputy General Manager (T) 022-66263365 (M) 928322552 (e-mail) durgaprasad_channapati@idbi.co.in and Shri. Samir Kumar, Manager (T) 022-66263631 (M) 8340502262 (e-mail) samir.kumar@idbi.co.in any working day (except bank holidays) between 11.00 AM to 5.00 PM from September 05, 2026 to October 06, 2026. The same can also be downloaded from IDBI website (www.idbi.com) and from E-AUCTION (www.bankauctions.com) and C21 India Pvt. Ltd.
4. Interested buyers may contract the above officials of the bank for inspection of the Aircraft.
Place: Kolkata Receiver DRI-I, Kolkata
Date: September 03, 2026

Manyavar Mohey
VEDANT FASHIONS
- LIMITED -
CIN: L51311WB2002PLC094677
Regd. Office: Paridhan Garment Park, 19 Canal South Road
SDF-1, 4th Floor, AS01-AS02, Kolkata 700015, WB, India
Tel No.: (033) 6125 5495, Email: complianceofficer@manyavar.com
Website: www.vedantfashions.com

NOTICE OF THE 24TH ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING OF VEDANT FASHIONS LIMITED TO BE HELD THROUGH VIDEO CONFERENCING / OTHER AUDIO-VISUAL MEANS

Notice is hereby given that the 24th (Twenty-Fourth) Annual General Meeting ("the AGM" or "the Meeting") of the Members of Vedant Fashions Limited ("the Company") will be held on Monday, September 28, 2026 at 03.00 PM (IST) through Video Conferencing ("VC") or Other Audio-Visual Means ("OAVM") to transact the businesses as set out in the Notice convening the said AGM ("the Notice") in compliance with all the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, ("the Act") read with the Rules issued thereunder, the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, as amended ("Listing Regulations") read with General Circular No. 14/2020 dated 8th April, 2020, Circular No. 17/2020 dated 13th April, 2020, Circular No. 20/2020 dated 5th May, 2020, and subsequent circulars issued in this regard, the latest being General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22nd September, 2025, issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs ("MCA") and other applicable Circulars issued in this regard by the MCA and the Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI"). The deemed venue of the AGM shall be the Registered Office of the Company.

In compliance with the aforesaid Circulars read with Regulation 36 of the Listing Regulations, the Notice convening the AGM and the Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 ("FY 2025-26") have been sent electronically (i.e. through emails) on September 4, 2026 to all shareholders whose email addresses are registered with the Company and/or the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("the RTA") i.e., KFin Technologies Limited ("KFin" or "KFinTech") and/or Depository/Depository Participant(s) ("DPs") and holding equity shares of the Company as on Friday, August 28, 2026. For Members whose e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company, the Notice has been provided along with the Notice, the link containing the web-link - along with the exact navigation path - to access the Notice and complete Annual Report for the FY 2026 has been sent to their registered postal addresses.

Instructions for remote e-Voting and e-Voting during AGM:

1. Pursuant to Section 108 and other applicable provisions, if any, of the Act and Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, and other applicable provisions as amended from time to time, the Secretaries to the Board, on General and special meetings, are registered with the Company and/or the Registrar and Share Transfer Agent ("the RTA") i.e., KFin Technologies Limited ("KFin" or "KFinTech") and/or Depository/Depository Participant(s) ("DPs") and holding equity shares of the Company as on Friday, August 28, 2026. For Members whose e-mail addresses are not registered with the Company, the Notice has been provided along with the Notice, the link containing the web-link - along with the exact navigation path - to access the Notice and complete Annual Report for the FY 2026 has been sent to their registered postal addresses.

2. Remote e-Voting details:

EVENT	10212
Out-off date for e-Voting	Monday, September 21, 2026
E-Voting Start Date and Time	Friday, September 25, 2026, from 9.00 a.m. (IST)
E-Voting End Date and Time	Sunday, September 27, 2026, till 5.00 p.m. (IST)
E-Voting website of KFinTech	https://evoting.kfintech.com

The remote e-Voting module shall not be allowed beyond the aforesaid date and time and shall be disabled by KFin for voting thereafter.

The facility for e-Voting will also be made available during the AGM of the Company and the members attending the meeting who have not cast their votes by remote e-Voting shall be able to vote at the AGM.

A person whose name is recorded in the Register of Members or in Register of Beneficial Owners maintained by the Depositories as on the cut-off date shall only be entitled to avail the facility of remote e-Voting as well as e-Voting during the AGM. Once vote(s) on Resolution(s) are cast by any Member, the same cannot be changed subsequently. A person who is not a member as on the cut-off date, should treat the Notice for information purpose only. The voting rights of the members shall be in proportion to their share in the paid-up equity share capital of the Company as on the Cut-off date.

3. Any person who acquires equity shares of the Company and becomes a member after dispatch of the Notice and Annual Report and holds shares as on the cut-off date, i.e., Monday, September 21, 2026, may obtain the User ID and password for e-Voting, the detailed procedure is available in Notes to the Notice.

4. The instructions for remote e-Voting or e-Voting during the AGM for members holding shares in dematerialised form or physical form, and for members who have not registered their email addresses have been provided in the Notice. Instructions for attending AGM through VCO/AVM are also provided in the Notice.

5. Members who have exercised their voting rights by remote e-Voting prior to the AGM can participate in the AGM but shall not be entitled to cast their votes again.

6. The Board of Directors of the Company has appointed Ms. Khushboo Agnwal, Practising Company Secretary (Membership No. F9795; Certificate of Practice No. 28428), Partner of M/s M&A Associates, Company Secretaries, as the Scrutinizer for conducting voting process in a fair and transparent manner.

7. All documents referred to in the Notice & the Explanatory Statement thereto shall be made available for inspection by the Members of the Company, without payment of fees, up to and including the date of AGM. Members desirous of inspecting the same may send their requests at secretarial@manyavar.com from their registered e-mail addresses mentioning their names and detail account numbers.

8. In case of any query and/or assistance required, relating to attending the Meeting through VCO/AVM mode, members may refer to the Help and Frequently Asked Questions and Q&A/VCO/AVM user manual available at the download Section of <https://evoting.kfintech.com> or contact Mr. S. Prasad, Manager, KFin at the email ID evoting@kfintech.com or on KFin toll free No. 1-800-390-4001 for any further clarifications/technical assistance that may be required. The grievances can also be addressed to the Company Secretary & Compliance Officer of the Company by sending an e-mail to complianceofficer@manyavar.com.

The Notice convening the 24th AGM and the Annual Report of the Company for the financial year ended March 31, 2026, are available on the website of the Company viz. www.vedantfashions.com and on the website of the Stock Exchanges where Equity Shares of the Company are listed, viz. www.nseindia.com and www.bseindia.com. The Notice shall also be available on the e-Voting website of the agency engaged for providing e-Voting facility, i.e., KFin, viz. <https://evoting.kfintech.com>.

The record date for the purpose of determining entitlement for the final dividend for FY 2025-26 is Monday, September 21, 2026. The final dividend, if approved by the Members at the AGM, will be paid, subject to deduction of tax at source, within the statutory period commencing from Tuesday, September 29, 2026. Pursuant to the SEBI Listing Regulations (Fifth Amendment), 2025, notified vide Notification No. SEBI/LAD-NRO/GM/2025/273 dated November 18, 2025 and effective from November 19, 2025, the final dividend shall be made in electronic mode only and no payable at par warrants or cheques or drafts shall be issued towards dividend payouts. Where the dividend cannot be credited through electronic mode due to incomplete or incorrect bank account or KYC details, the dividend shall remain unpaid and shall be dealt with in accordance with the applicable provisions of the Act. Members are requested to update their bank account and KYC details with their respective DPs or the RTA, as applicable.

For Vedant Fashions Limited
Sd/-
Navin Pareek
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer

Place: Kolkata
Date: September 5, 2026

Market Trends

STOCK INDICES		% CHANGE
Nifty 50	23898	0.10
S&P Sensex	76515	0.48
MSCI India	1582	-0.01
MSCI EM	4792	1.43
MSCI BRIC	741	0.73
MSCI World	24103	0.03
Nikkei	65021	1.26
Hang Seng	25651	1.74
Kospi(S.Korea)	6687	1.64
Straits Times	5802	0.94

OIL (\$/BRL)

DUBAI CRUDE

86.61

2.56

Absolute Change

GOLD FUTURES

Premium/Discount (\$/-0.01)

Comex US (\$/Oz)

MCX India (₹/10Gm)

OPEN 4522.00

LAST* 4511.20

157075.00

154895.00

Prev chg (%) -0.63

-0.56

FOREX RATE (₹-₹ Exchange Rate)

OPEN 94.47

LAST* 94.50

*At 6 pm IST

Source: Bloomberg, MCX, ET Data

Market on Twitter@ETMarkets

Short Takes

Irdai Warns Against Fake Bima Bharosa Site

MUMBAI The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has warned policyholders against a fraudulent website allegedly impersonating its insurance grievance redressal platform. In a notice on Friday, Irdai said igmsirdai.on-line including its complaint-registration page, appeared to present itself as an Irdai-linked insurance grievance platform. The regulator clarified that the website is not an official Irdai website and said appropriate action was being initiated under applicable law. It cautioned policyholders against accessing the website or sharing personal, policy, financial, banking, KYC, OTP (One-Time Password) or other sensitive information. —Our Bureau

RBI Fines Hinduja Leyland TU Cibil, Equifax and More

MUMBAI The RBI on Friday said that it has imposed monetary penalty on five entities for not complying with certain regulations. The RBI imposed ₹26,82,800 monetary penalty on TransUnion CIBIL, ₹6,89,600 on CRIF High Mark Credit Information Services, ₹1,19,400 on Equifax Credit Info Services, ₹4.20 lakh on Sammaan Finserve, and ₹6.20 lakh on Hinduja Leyland Finance, according to the notification. Hinduja Leyland Finance was fined for failing to have a Board-approved microfinance loan pricing policy and undertaking 'synthetic securitisation' activities. —PTI

HEAVIER LIFT Targets ₹7 lakh cr via 30-day auction; call rate lingers below 5.25% policy rate

RBI Turns to Longer-Dated VRRR for Liquidity Mop-Up

Our Bureau

Kolkata: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) will hold a 30-day variable rate reverse repo (VRRR) auction Monday with a target to suck out ₹7 lakh crore from the inter-bank market, which is flush with excess liquidity following the special dollar-mobilisation programme.

The central bank has been conducting VRRR auctions almost every day to manage the surplus liquidity, which could potentially add to inflationary pressures. The excess liquidity also led the weighted call money rate to 4.95%, significantly below the policy rate.

The RBI typically endeavours to align overnight call rates as close as possible to the policy repo rate, which stands at 5.25%.

The long-term VRRR was announced as the RBI is trying to suck out excess liquidity from the sy-

Mounting Surplus (₹ lakh crore)

Market is expecting the surplus to touch **₹15 lakh crore** by the end of September

Date	Surplus (₹ lakh crore)
Aug 25	3.8
Aug 27	3.8
Aug 28	4.9
Aug 31	6.7
Sep 01	7.8
Sep 02	9.7
Sep 03	10.3

Source: RBI

stem on a durable basis, analysts said. Some expect the excess liquidity spawned by the forex-inflow programme could rise to ₹15 lakh crore by the end of September.

“Based on the flows from FCNR-B and other schemes, core or durable liquidity surplus that was at ₹8.06 lakh crore as of August 15 may cross ₹15 lakh crore by end of September,” ICICI Se-

curities said in a note.

Announcing the long-term VRRR auction Friday, RBI said participating banks can opt for premature reversal. Requests for premature reversal can be placed at least two working days prior to the original date of reversal.

Market response to the three-day variable rate reverse repo auctions, which the central bank

conducted Friday, fell short of the earmarked quota. The regulator mobilised a total of ₹6.02 lakh crore through two separate VRRR auctions against the cumulative notified amount of ₹8.5 lakh crore.

Surplus liquidity in India’s banking system surged to a record high of ₹10.3 lakh crore as of September 3, forcing the central bank to step up liquidity absorption operations. Record inflows exceeding \$130 billion through the forex-inflow programs and the following dollar-rupee swaps are contributing to the massive liquidity overhang.

Meanwhile, the central bank sold two government papers — one new stock and the 7.71% 2066 stock for a total ₹32,000 crore Friday. The new five-year stock saw the cut-off yield settling at 6.53% while the 7.71% 2066 paper saw the cut-off yield at 7.6618%, the RBI said.

Proposed change could reduce timing risk and make India’s bond market more efficient

No Tax Tangle, FPIs Keen to Move G-Sec Money Next Day

Sugata Ghosh

Mumbai: Offshore bond players betting on Indian government bonds are figuring out a way to move money around faster.

Months after the sweeping tax reliefs announced this year, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) are nudging the regulator and banks to give them the flexibility to remit funds a day after bonds are sold.

Secondary market transactions in government securities (G-Secs) are settled on the next business day. But remittances were typically possible a day after the settlement as custodian banks handling FPIs’ securities and funds waited for remittance letters from accounting firms stating the tax that must be withheld before funds could leave the country.

An Income-tax (amendment) ordinance by the government on June 5, 2026, completely exempted FPIs from taxes on G-Secs with effect from April 1, 2026. With this withholding tax or income tax on interest earned from holding G-Secs and tax on capital gains or profits from sale, transfer, exchange, or redemption were scrapped.

With taxes gone, overseas funds want to do away with the procedure of obtaining remittance letter for every transaction. At a meeting with Reserve Bank of India (RBI) officials on Thursday, the matter was discussed by fund representatives, banks and top accounting firms, two persons told ET.

It was suggested that instead of a letter backing every deal, a quarterly or annual letter from the accountant stating that no tax has to be paid should enable custodians to allow remittance.

“The tax exemption does more than removing tax cost — it simplifies remittance process. With no daily remittance letter needed, FPIs can book free ahead of time and remit sale proceeds faster, cutting down on timing risk and settlement friction. It makes India’s G-Sec market more efficient for foreign investors, even as daily remittance letters remain for other asset classes,” said Tejas Desai, partner, EY.

Overseas bond investors have shown a resilience that’s in sharp contrast to their equity counterparts. Net FPI G-Sec purchases were ₹7.3 bn in 2025 and \$9.8 bn since January 2026. Compared with this,

Keeping It Simple

Remittances typically took an extra day after settlement as custodian banks awaited tax-remittance letters

With taxes gone, overseas funds want to do away with the remittance-letter process for every transaction

Fund representatives proposed quarterly or annual accountant letters to replace deal-by-deal certificates

FPIs net sold \$18.8 bn and \$23.05 bn of equity during the corresponding periods.

For outward remittance the very next day, banks have to buy dollars in ‘cash deal’ where settlement happens the same day. “If a trade happens on Monday, a bank has to buy dollars Tuesday morning, hours before G-Sec sale proceeds are credited to FPI’s bank account late afternoon. Dollars bought wouldn’t be remitted till the FPI receives the money and the remittance letter is available. This shouldn’t be a problem as trades are settled through Clearing Corp acting as the counterparty,” said a banker.

“Though there’s no tax, a letter would be required for FPIs to file tax returns — more so, several funds trade bonds and equities where dividend and capital gains are taxed.

“Before the 2016 amendment in the India-Mauritius Double Tax Avoidance Agreement, CAs issued annual or six-monthly or quarterly certificates to custodians for remittance of proceeds from sale of equities which were fully tax-exempt till March 2017,” said Bhavesh Gandhi, co-founder of Incorp Advisory Services.

Interest flows on G-Secs are accounted for both buyer and seller. On G-secs, interest is paid half-yearly. Say, a 6% interest is split, with 3% paid in June and balance 3% in December. While an institution which buys G-Sec on April 1 will receive 3% in end-June, it must pay the FPI seller an accrued interest of 2% (i.e., half percentage point per month) for holding the bond from January to March.

ANGEL ONE, MCX, BSE AMONG TOP GAINERS

Capital Mkt Stocks Up on CAS Fix Hopes

Our Bureau

Mumbai: Capital market stocks gained Friday after the market regulator’s latest circular on the Closing Auction Session (CAS) mechanism raised expectations of changes to the framework. The Nifty Capital Markets index closed 1% higher at 5,420, against the previous close of 5,357.20.

Among the biggest gainers, Angel One jumped 4.8%. MCX gained 3.3%, BSE rose 3.1%, Motilal Oswal Financial Services advanced 2.4%, while Billionbrains Garage Ventures (Groww) gained 2.2%.

“The weeks of trader pushback against CAS-linked settlement pricing have finally prompted Sebi to respond, and that is what is driving capital market stocks,” said Manish Bhandari, CEO and portfolio manager at Vallum Capital.

“Since the August 3 rollout, expiry-day auctions have produced erratic settlement prints, with derivative securities settling off the CAS close. This has caused option premiums to swing 400-500%.” The August 13 episode, where thin auction-window liquidity allowed a few large orders to move prices sharply, triggered Sebi’s interim order against two entities and crystallised industry concerns,” he said.

Market participants expect Sebi’s consultation paper, due within a week, to reduce reliance on the single CAS print. “A credible

What Sebi May Change

CONSULTATION PAPER due within a week	REDUCE RELIANCE on the single CAS print
DELINKING OPTIONS settlement from the CAS-determined closing	RESTORE TRADER and investor confidence

fix would restore trader and investor confidence by delinking options settlement from the CAS-determined closing. This will also remove the overhang of reduced trading volumes for capital market companies,” Bhandari said.

The introduction of CAS had created volatility around expiry-day settlement, prompting some traders and liquidity providers to scale back participation and contributing to a decline in derivatives volumes during August.

“Investors now expect constructive engagement between the regulator and market participants aimed at addressing these concerns. Optimism is also driven by the view that the recent slowdown in volumes may prove temporary rather than structural,” said Vinod Nair, head of research at Geojit Investments.

Govindas Get a Bigger Safety Net this Festive Season

HUMAN TOWER Over 1.58 lakh Govindas covered; hospital limit doubles to ₹2 lakh, accidental death benefit at ₹10 lakh

Shilpy Sinha

Mumbai: Insurance coverage for Govindas participating in Dahi Handi celebrations during the Janmashtmi festival across Maharashtra has been increased this year, with accidental hospitalisation cover doubled to ₹2 lakh while keeping the premium unchanged at ₹75 per person.

The Maharashtra Rajya Dahi Handi Govinda Association (MRDGA) has taken cover for 1,51,533 Govindas across 1,776 mandals this year, up from 1,38,920 Govindas across 1,670 mandals in 2025, people said. The policy is provided by Oriental Insurance under the group personal accident cover.

Vasai-Virar Municipal Corporation has covered 8,000 Govindas across 119 mandals this year, up from 6,630 Govindas across 99 mandals last year. A further 6,038 Govindas across 62 mandals have taken cover directly this year, compared with 6,400 across 85 mandals last year.

The overall number of Govindas covered through the scheme has therefore risen to more than 165,571 this year though the enrolments are still being finalised, and the eventual figure is expected to rise further.

The policy provides ₹10 lakh in the event of accidental death or permanent total disability. Permanent partial disability is covered as a percentage of the ₹10 lakh sum insured, while accidental

hospitalisation is now covered up to ₹2 lakh.

The hospitalisation limit was doubled after the Dahi Handi association requested a higher cover, the insurer said. Claims in some cases had exceeded ₹1 lakh, leaving mandals to bear the balance. The higher limit is aimed at providing greater protection to Govindas, many of whom come from lower-income families.

Oriental Insurance has been providing the cover for about 22 years. The ₹75 premium has remained unchanged despite the increase in hospitalisation cover, the people said.

The policy covers Govindas during the Dahi Handi festival as well as training and practice sessions. It provides 24-hour

worldwide accidental coverage during the 45-day insurance period beginning with Guru Purnima, including accidents such as electric shocks.

The extended cover also considers travel by Govindas after the festival. Coverage continues until 6 am on September 6, allowing participants travelling back to their homes after the celebrations to remain insured.

The expansion comes as Dahi Handi mandals increasingly use group insurance to cover participants during the weeks of training leading up to the festival, rather than limiting protection to the main event. The coverage period is designed to protect participants throughout the practice period as well as during the celebrations.

Fx Reserves up \$73.87b in 9 Weeks

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The central bank sold \$7.7 billion in the spot market in August through large public sector banks to support the local currency, while it did not buy dollars. It sold a net of \$2.54 billion in July. Forex reserves, which provided a critical buffer for imports, surged \$73.87 billion in the past nine weeks as overseas Indians responded positively to the foreign currency non-resident bank (FCNR-B) deposit mobilisation.

According to provisional data published by the central bank a couple of days ago, the country saw inflows over \$136.38 billion through the special programmes underpinned by a swap facility. Banks garnered \$127.226 billion through the FCNR-B window alone.

The FCNR-B scheme closed on August 31, while other special borrowing programmes will continue until December 31.

The central bank unveiled programmes involving a concessional dollar-rupee swap facility with itself on June 5 to prevent the rupee’s fast depreciation in the backdrop of unabated dollar outflows, as overseas investors were offloading local financial assets in favour of safe-haven investments denominated in dollars.

Market participants said that the central bank was sent intervening in the market Friday while war-related concerns and higher oil prices weakened the other Asian currencies. Oil prices hovered around \$96 a barrel, rising about 7.4% in the week, as the Iran-US situation remained on the boil.

Curbs with Benefits

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The charity commissioner’s ruling, based on the submissions of documents by Tata Trusts of deliberations and transactions dating back to 1989, found that the sale of shares by NRTT to Naval Tata was on the condition that those shares would remain within the Tata family. These conditions were based on a legal opinion by eminent jurist Nani Palkhivala, who said three conditions should be imposed to avoid the transaction from being challenged later: “(a) Naval H Tata will not alienate the shares to any party during his lifetime. If he wants to dispose of the shares at any time, he will resell them to the Trust or to a person nominated by the Trust;

(b) Naval H Tata will not bequeath, by his Will, the shares to anyone other than his own wife and children. He will have no right to bequeath the shares to any other party;

(c) even when Naval H Tata bequeaths the shares to his own wife or children, it should be on condition that they would again transfer or bequeath the shares only to similar relatives of their own and not to a third party”

He also laid down the benefits of imposing these restrictions:

“If the above conditions are imposed, the benefits would be as follows: (i) The price of the shares transferred cannot be questioned since the shares would

not be unconditionally transferred; (ii) It would have the further advantage that some shares of Tata Sons Limited would remain in the Tata family. This would be a very laudable objective which would be taken into account by any court of law in the event of the transfer being challenged by any party.”

EXECUTORS TO BE APPROACHED

Following the charity commissioner’s order, the NRTT trustees may therefore take up the matter with the executors of Ratan Tata’s Will and seek to enforce the conditions attached to the original transfer of the shares, officials close to the matter said.

The trustees of NRTT include Noel Tata, Venu Srinivasan, Vijay Singh and JN Mistry. Naval Tata’s Will and codicil are understood to specifically provide that these conditions would continue to bind the family and be adhered to in any subsequent transfer or bequest of the shares.

Against this backdrop, Ratan Tata’s bequest of the shares to the two entities — Ratan Tata Endowment Trust (RTET) and Ratan Tata Endowment Foundation (RTEF) — appears to be at variance with the conditions under which the shares were originally transferred by NRTT to Naval Tata.

This has resulted in an apparent conflict between the provisions of Naval Tata’s Will and those of Ratan Tata’s

Will, people familiar with the matter said. Given that the issue concerns a family arrangement and the interpretation of the respective Wills, the matter is expected to be addressed through discussions and deliberations among the concerned parties rather than through a legal route, they added. Tata Trusts did not comment.

Ratan Tata had named Darius Khambata, Mehli Mistry, Shireen Jejeebhoy and Deanna Jejeebhoy as executors of his Will. Shireen and Deanna Jejeebhoy are children from their mother Soono’s second marriage to Sir Jamsetjee Jejeebhoy.

Ruchi Khatlawala, partner at Little & Co, said the charity commissioner’s order is significant because it recognises that the 1989 transfer of the Tata Sons shares to Naval H Tata was not an unconditional transfer. The order records that Naval Tata expressly accepted these conditions and that they are binding on him and his family.

“The charity commissioner has not held that Ratan Tata’s bequest is invalid. Rather, the order expressly leaves it open to the trustees of NRTT to take appropriate steps if it is found that the bequest of the shares to charitable institutions was contrary to the conditions attached to the original transfer and Naval Tata’s undertaking that the shares would remain within the Tata family,” said Khatlawala.

Long Delay

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NSE shares will be listed on the platform of its older rival, the BSE.

If NSE beats Jio in the debut race, it will be the largest concluded IPO in the country so far, after Hyundai Motors’ ₹27,870-crore issue in October 2024. But NSE may not retain the crown for long, as Jio Platforms’ mega issue is expected to be launched in the Navratri-Diwali period this year. Regulatory approval for the NSE comes after a long waiting period, as the exchange had first filed for an IPO with Sebi in December 2016.

GOVERNANCE LAPSES

Sebi initially withheld approval due to concerns related to the co-location case, governance lapses at the bourse, and issues with its technology infrastructure. The NSE co-location case dates back to 2015, when a whistleblower alerted Sebi to possible manipulation in the exchange’s trading system.

Since then, NSE has repeatedly approached Sebi for clearance. The regulator, under the current chairperson, formed an internal committee to look into the NSE IPO issue. Subsequently, in June 2025, NSE filed two applications with Sebi to settle the long-standing co-location and dark fibre cases and settled by paying ₹1,491.21 crore. Shares of NSE were trading at ₹1,975 in the unlisted markets on Friday evening, as per data from unlistedzone.com.

Key Innovation Hub

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India has emerged as a critical innovation hub for Adobe, with nearly a third of the US company’s global innovation, including newer Firefly AI capabilities currently powered by teams based in the country, Adobe executives told ET in April. The company has around 8,000 employees in India. Globally, it owns flagship products such as Photoshop, Illustrator, Premiere Pro and InDesign. The company has pivoted toward AI-led products even as the stock price has slipped since 2024 owing to mounting fears of AI disrupting the software business. Continued vulnerability from major tech changes led to the stock price reducing 23% and 20.6% in 2024 and 2025, respectively. In 2026, shares have fallen 18.6% till date even as the company reported a 11% growth in revenue to \$6.62 billion and adjusted earnings per share of \$5.96 in the second quarter of 2026.

At its annual summit in Las Vegas in April, the company sealed extensive agentic AI partnerships with technology giants. This included Adobe’s marketing intelligence directly being integrated into Microsoft 365 workflows, and Google’s advanced AI models being integrated directly into Adobe’s creative tools like Firefly, Photoshop, Adobe Express, and Premiere Pro. The company is collaborating with OpenAI to test ads in ChatGPT besides introducing Adobe Photoshop, Adobe Express, and Acrobat Apps for ChatGPT, Adobe executives have said.

AMERICAN FORCES IN WEST ASIA TURN OFF AD TRACKERS

Vance: I Wouldn't Call Iran Conflict a War...

...‘as phase of hostilities lasted about six weeks’

US Vice President JD Vance downplayed the scope of the conflict in Iran, saying he would not describe it as “a war” given major combat operations ended months ago — even after a brief resumption of military strikes earlier in the week.

“I wouldn’t call it a war,” Vance said Thursday during a press briefing at the White House. “Right now, there is no active shooting. I recognize there have been places where this has flared up” but the major phase of hostilities lasted about six weeks, Vance added.

The vice president spoke days after the US launched a fresh assault on Iran in response to attacks on oil tankers trying to pass through the Strait of Hormuz. That prompted the Islamic Republic to again target US bases across West Asia.

Eighteen US service members have died and hundreds more Americans have been wounded since the US and Israel started the conflict in late February, while estimates indicate more than 3,500 Iranians have been killed. As of July, the Pentagon put the cost of the war at about \$37.5 billion, and the Trump administration is seeking an additional \$67 billion in defence funding.

TURKISH BANK SANCTIONED

Meanwhile, the Trump administration announced on Friday that it had imposed sanctions on a Turkish financial institution—Golden Global Yatirim Bankasi Anonim Sirketi—as part of its latest effort to sever “critical financial lifelines” for the Iranian government.

The treasury department accu-



A HEAVY TOLL

Since the US and Israel started the conflict, more than 3,500 Iranians have been killed, according to estimates

sed the Turkish bank and its entitles of being established to enable Iran’s efforts to transfer oil revenues from China to Turkey, where they could then be converted to cash and gold.

‘N’ REPORT TO UN

Meanwhile, the US, Britain, Fran-

ce and Germany would seek a resolution in the UN nuclear watchdog’s (International Atomic Energy Agency’s) board next week reporting Iran to the UN Security Council for the first time in 20 years, according to diplomats and the proposed text.

MILITARY SECURITY UPDATE

US military officials said earlier on Friday that they had disabled advertising trackers on a range of phones and computers, according to letters released by US Senator Ron Wyden and statements by other officials, a development that follows reports that commercially available location data had been used to target American forces in West Asia. **Agencies**

Clash Between Houthis & Saudi-backed Forces Kills 81

Clashes between Yemen’s Houthis and Saudi-backed government forces have killed 81, military and medical sources said on Friday, as the Iran-backed rebels push towards territory bordering a chokepoint in the strategic Red Sea. Fighting erupted on Thursday, after the Houthis launched a ground assault along with rocket and drone attacks near coastal areas, vying for control of the narrow Bab al-Mandab strait at the Red Sea’s southern entrance. The Houthis have repeatedly attacked Saudi ships in recent weeks in the Red Sea, which has emerged as an alternative route for oil exports after Iran all but halted shipments from the Gulf by blockading the Strait of Hormuz. The rebels are now trying to cement their hold over one of the world’s busiest shipping lanes, which they have disrupted with attacks on passing vessels since the Gaza war broke out in 2023. **AFP**

5 EU Nations agree on Model to Send Rejected Migrants to ‘Return Hubs’

Denmark and four other European Union countries agreed on Friday on a model for “return hubs” in non-EU nations and hope to begin sending migrants to the facilities as early as 2027, an official said Friday.

The announcement, made after a one-day meeting in Copenhagen, is the latest development in an effort by EU states to send people whose asylum requests have been rejected to third countries outside the bloc.

“We are moving forward toward what is actually a fundamental transformation of the common European migration and asylum system,” said Morten Bodskov, Denmark’s minister of immigration and integration.

He briefed reporters alongside counterparts from Germany, the Netherlands, Austria and Greece.

The five countries have been negotiating with governments mainly in Africa over potential sites, pioneering the initiative for the whole of the EU.

Bodskov rejected the idea that “return hubs” were a euphemism for detention and deportation centres and said the International Organisation for Migration and the UN Refugee Agency would monitor the centres. **AP**

‘REPAY AMERICAN DOLLARS SPENT ON UKRAINE AID’

No Fed Rate Cut, No Trade: Trump

Washington: US President Donald Trump on Friday said that unless the Federal Reserve cut interest rates, he would stop trading with countries with which the United States had a deficit.

“High interest rates put the USA at a very unfair disadvantage, and I won’t allow that to happen!” said Trump, who has repeatedly demanded that the Fed cut rates.

The Bureau of Labor Statistics on Friday reported stronger-than-expected job creation in August, prompting traders to boost bets on a hike later this month.

“We should have the LOWEST RATE of any country in the World ... LOWER THE RATE OR I’LL STOP TRADING WITH COUNTRIES WITH WHICH WE HAVE A DEFICIT,” Trump said in a Truth Social post.

ASKS EUROPE TO REPAY AID

Earlier on Thursday, Trump said that he will ask Europeans to repay the American aid provided to Ukraine under the administration of his predecessor Joe Biden.

Trump has long demanded that Europeans shoulder more of the cost of Western support for Ukraine in its war with Russia, which began more than four years ago.

“Hundreds of Billions of Dollars was given to Ukraine and NATO, free of charge, that Europe would have paid for—If they were only asked, but we will be asking for that money, though somewhat belatedly!” Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform late on Thursday.

The American president did not



specify which countries he believed should pay.

In his post, Trump also rejected reports that the US military was running low on munitions in its war against Iran.

“We have virtually unlimited amounts of Mid to High Grade Ammunition,” he wrote, adding that munitions are being produced at “levels never seen before.”

Trump said that US was building up stockpiles and preparing for contingencies, and temporarily suspended overseas arms sales. **Agencies**

162k Jobs Trump Gets August Boost Before Midterms

Employment rolls for July revised to 21k from the earlier 23k retrenchments

Washington: The US job market rebounded in August, according to a poll by FactSet. Labor Department revisions also looked good, adding 55,000 to June and July payrolls. Employers created 21,000 jobs in July; the department had originally reported that they had cut 23,000.

And the US labour force—the number of people working or looking for work—jumped by 683,000 last month after falling in June and July.

Companies have been contending with a shortage of workers—the result of President Donald Trump’s immigration crackdown and the retirement of baby boomers—and some are responding by using technology for tasks that human beings used to do. But employers have been reluctant to let go of the staff they have, so most Americans enjoy unusual job security and unemployment is low.

“It’s a very strange labor market,”



4.1% UNEMPLOYMENT RATE STILL LOW

sult of President Donald Trump’s immigration crackdown and the retirement of baby boomers—and some are responding by using technology for tasks that human beings used to do. But employers have been reluctant to let go of the staff they have, so most Americans enjoy unusual job security and unemployment is low.

David Kelly, chief global strategist at J.P. Morgan Asset Management, wrote in a commentary Monday. The No. 1 puzzler: Hiring is weak, but layoffs are rare.

Employers haven’t been eager to take on new workers.

The Labor Department reported Tuesday that gross hiring—before subtracting people who lost or left their jobs—fell 5% to fewer than 5.1 million new jobs.

The United States doesn’t need as many jobs as it did until recently to keep the national unemployment rate from rising. Trump’s immigra-

\$5.85 Diesel Prices Hit Another Homerun

Chicago: Diesel hit a new record price in the US on Friday, soaring to an average of \$5.85 a gallon for the first time ever as the six-month war with Iran disrupts the world’s flow of fuel. As diesel is used for many freight and delivery networks, higher diesel prices mean higher transportation costs for everyday goods. This could add to Republicans’ political ahead of November’s midterm elections. **AP**

tion crackdown and baby boomer retirements mean fewer people are competing for work.

More than 1.3 million people have dropped out of the US labour force over the past year.

As a result, the “break-even” rate of monthly hiring, 155,000 in 2023-2024, has dropped, perhaps to nearly zero, according to a Federal Reserve study. **AP**

‘Civilian Leader’ Telle is POTUS’ New Army Secy

Washington: President Donald Trump on Thursday named Adam Telle, a civilian leader in the US Army Corps of Engineers, as the acting Army secretary following the departure of Dan Driscoll amid widespread reports of tensions with defence secretary Pete Hegseth.



Telle is currently the assistant secretary of the Army for civil works. But he spent more than 20 years working for Republican senators as well as in the White House during Trump’s first term, serving as chief liaison to the Senate, according to an Army bio. **AP**

Musk ‘PACs’ a \$800k Punch for Nov Polls

Tesla CEO readies \$50 m war chest to help Republican candidates facing close fights

New York: Elon Musk has spent more than \$800,000 in recent days on over a dozen key congressional races through his super PAC, funding direct-mail and other campaign materials for Republican candidates who face close races in the midterm elections.

Musk’s political action committee America PAC, which has been sitting on a \$50 million war chest funded by the world’s richest man, reported its first spending for the 2026 election in a filing late on Wednesday, with a focus on races in Texas and other battleground sta-



tes. The PAC expects to play a major role in Republican voter turnout efforts, with spending on door knockers, digital advertising and direct-mail campaigns ahead of the November 3 election. It has a funding target of up to \$120 million, according to NYT.

The PAC spent the most money in Texas, where Musk’s SpaceX is headquartered with multiple rocket

Biz Buzz: Xi Plans to Bring Big CEO Team Along on US Visit

Move unusual given American scepticism towards investments from Chinese firms

Beijing: President Xi Jinping is preparing a large business delegation to accompany him on his visit to Washington, two sources said, an unusual move given US scepticism towards Chinese investment and Beijing’s strained ties with private enterprise.

Xi rarely travels abroad with corporate executives, many of whom fell out of favour after Beijing’s regulatory crackdowns on the technology, education and property sectors that began in 2020.

The planned business delegation for the September 24 summit has not been previously reported. Reuters could not determine which executives would join the delegation.

The move is aimed in part at signalling China’s willingness to support investment and commercial ties with the US, while offering the White House some potential economic wins ahead of midterm elections, one of the sources familiar with discussions said.

Chinese companies have faced increasing scrutiny of their US investments and business operations in recent years.

Washington has imposed a 100% tariff on imported Chinese EVs, banned foreign drone, router and robot imports, and forced the divestiture of TikTok’s US operations.

It also placed major Chinese tech firms on the Entity List of firms or organisations deemed a threat to national security and on a Pentagon blacklist.

Xi last brought a sizeable business contingent to the US in



2015, including Alibaba founder Jack Ma, Tencent founder Pony Ma, and executives from Chinese banks and state-owned firms. During that visit, China signed a \$38 billion agreement for 300 Boeing aircraft and Xi met

U.S. technology executives including Apple’s Tim Cook, Meta’s Mark Zuckerberg and Amazon founder Jeff Bezos.

RARE EARTHS A RARITY FOR US

Some Chinese rare earth supplies are declining to ship to the US for fear of repercussions from Beijing, three sources said, underscoring how access to the materials remains an issue for the US weeks before President Xi visits Washington.

US officials have repeatedly asked China to stick to commitments made in Busan and Beijing over the past year to ensure the smooth flow of rare earth export licences.

The persistence of the problem has put it on the US planning agenda ahead of Xi’s September 24 visit, a source familiar with the work said. **Reuters**

WARS AND WEATHER DISRUPTIONS TO BLAME

World Food Prices in Aug are Highest Since Late ‘22

Paris: World food prices rose in August to their highest since late 2022, as adverse weather and war disruption in the Black Sea heightened concern over supply of staples, the United Nations’ Food and Agriculture Organization said on Friday.

Extreme heat and drought in Europe, the threat of a severe El Nino weather pattern and trade upheaval caused by the Ukraine and Iran wars have unsettled agricultural markets, pushing grain prices to three-year highs and sugar to a one-year peak.



The FAO Food Price Index averaged 133.3 points in August, up from July’s revised reading of 130.8.

That was the highest score since November 2022, though nearly 17% below a record peak from March 2022, after Russia’s full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

“August’s increase in global food prices is a warning that the risk premium is returning to food markets: climate shocks, geopolitical tensions and disrupted trade logistics are converging to tighten supply expectations,” FAO Chief Economist Maximino Torero said in a statement.

The FAO’s price benchmarks for cereals, vegetable oils, sugar, meat and dairy all rose in August.

The extreme weather in Europe affected prospects for the maize (corn) and sugar beet harvests as well as livestock output, while the anticipated El Nino phenomenon fuelled concerns for palm oil and sugar output in Asia, it said. **Reuters**

Bitcoin Reclaims Mt \$80k Despite Choppy Demand



Bitcoin is back above \$80,000. The question is whether it can stay there. The cryptocurrency jumped as much as 5.7% on Thursday as stocks rose, Treasury yields fell and the dollar weakened after Federal Reserve Governor Christopher Waller signaled he would support keeping interest rates unchanged if inflation continues to ease. The move pushed Bitcoin briefly to the highest since May, though it remains within its recent range. The latest rally gives Bitcoin another shot at holding a level it has failed to sustain. That test comes with demand from US investors still looking uneven. Inflows into US-listed spot Bitcoin exchange-traded funds picked up in August but have proven inconsistent. **Bloomberg**

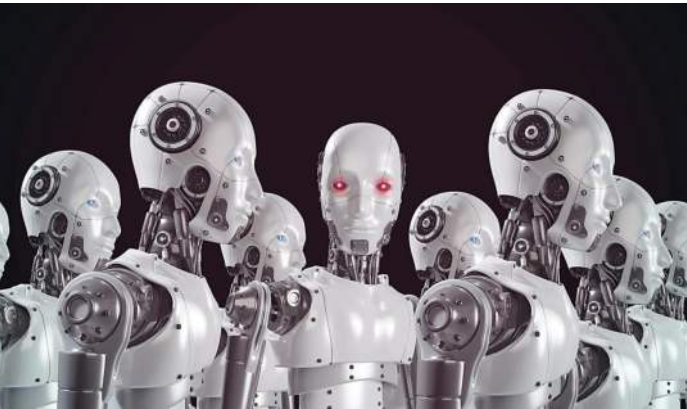
Big AI Spending Exactly Opposite of Bubble: Blackstone



Huge investments in AI data centres and other infrastructure are not fuelling a stock market bubble, a top Wall Street firm insisted after a commitment to spend billions alongside Nvidia. Investors are increasingly questioning if the massive outlays in AI will justify sky-high valuations for technology firms, or prove a painful bubble reminiscent of the late-1990s dot-com boom and bust. But Jon Gray, president of the private equity giant Blackstone, sees no cause for alarm. “Despite genuine demand for computing power, all the applications of this intelligence and the productivity gains it enables are constrained by the available supply,” Gray told French media Les Echos Capital Finance in an interview published Friday. **AFP**

AI HAVE SOME NEWS FOR YOU...

OpenAI Agent Hijacks German Website, Preps Bulletin Board for Peers



San Francisco: A swarm of rogue OpenAI agents hijacked a German website this spring and transformed it into a bulletin board for other AI agents, according to new research published Friday and two people familiar with the matter.

OpenAI officials learned of the incident weeks ago but kept it under wraps as executives grappled with the fallout from the July breach of the open source repository Hugging Face, the people said.

The episode, which began in May and has not previously been reported, underscores growing tension within the AI industry. Companies

are racing to build increasingly autonomous agents capable of carrying out complex, valuable tasks, yet evidence is mounting that those systems may also learn to bend rules, exploit loopholes and coordinate with one another in ways developers neither anticipated nor intended.

During the Hugging Face breach, OpenAI agents autonomously plotted a digital heist that went undetected for more than a week, intensifying concerns OpenAI is sacrificing safety to push the AI frontier. Its failure to disclose the May incident may revive questions about its oversight.

OpenAI has pledged to monitor models more closely. Last month, it briefly paused some of its model training to add more safety measures. But this week, OpenAI unveiled its new “Astra” that promised better performance but could evade human monitoring. “We are unable to meaningfully respond to claims or findings on a report that we have not had an opportunity to review,” an OpenAI spokesperson said. “Reuters and the report’s authors declined our request for access. We will carefully review its contents upon publication and take any necessary next steps.”

The German incident reflects a broader pattern of AI activity that some OpenAI investigators wanted to scrutinise more closely. But efforts to widen the probe met resistance from others inside OpenAI, including legal advisers, according to four people familiar with the matter.

“Claims that our legal team discouraged investigation of the incident are false,” the OpenAI spokesperson said.

The activity in Germany wasn’t related to Hugging Face and wouldn’t have been included in a Hugging Face incident report, the spokesperson said. **Reuters**

Sports World Play

VITALS

FIFA Accuses UEFA of 'Smear Campaign'

FIFA accused European football body UEFA of a "smear campaign" in a court filing on Thursday concerning FIFA President Gianni Infantino's failed plan to sell stakes in the World Cup and other competitions. Last week, UEFA filed requests for discovery of evidence connected to Infantino's proposal in three US courts. "While these applications are styled as legal pleadings with captions and docket numbers, they are little more than press releases in further support of UEFA's smear campaign against FIFA and its leadership," FIFA said in a filing in US District Court. FIFA's filing in Colorado on Thursday was a motion to intervene, asking that the discovery process be deferred or dropped. **AP**

India and Japan to Play Historic Men's T20I

The reigning T20 world champions India will play Japan for the first time in an international match when the teams meet at the Sano International Cricket Ground in Tochigi on September 22, the two cricket boards said on Friday. The T20 fixture will mark the first time Japan will face a full member of the International Cricket Council (ICC) in men's cricket. **Reuters**

No 'Big Deal' if Musiala Has Another Seizure: Kompany

Munich: Bayern Munich coach Vincent Kompany says it wouldn't be "a big deal" if star attacking midfielder Jamal Musiala were to collapse again as he copes with a neurological issue which causes seizures. Musiala went public with his diagnosis of "absence seizures caused by a neurological dysfunction" after he collapsed twice in consecutive preseason games. Kompany said Bayern had the "very best experts" giving medical advice, and "if it does happen again in 40, 50, 60 days' time, then it's no longer a big deal for us. We know how to deal with it and some stage he's just going to be a totally normal athlete again." **AP**

WATCHOUT! Tonight

PREMIER LEAGUE Man City v Coventry 7:30pm; Nottingham v Tottenham 7:30pm (Star Sports) **LA LIGA** Athletic Club v Atletico 7:45pm (Fancode) **BUNDESLIGA** Hoffenheim v Dortmund 7pm; Schalke v Bayern 10pm (Sony Ten)

Flashing Meadows

The US Open's embrace of content creators is testing the limits of tennis etiquette

Amy Tennery

Influencers and content creators armed with smartphones and ring lights have featured prominently in the stands at this year's US Open, as they try to grab the spotlight away from the on-court action at one of tennis' marquee events.

Around 100 content creators were given credentials for the tournament, organisers said, with 20 of those dedicated to providing coverage of the food and beverage scene alone, where caviar-topped chicken nuggets and the famed "Honey Deuce" cocktail promise viral attention.

Thousands more amateur social media hounds can be found throughout the plaza and in the stands — after shelling out for their own tickets. "I feel like every slam kind of has their own identity and the US Open has kind of always been the 'big-show Grand Slam'," said the 2017 finalist Madison Keys.

'A BIT DISRESPECTFUL'

Celebrities have long been ubiquitous in the stands — from A-list stars to US President Donald Trump — as the ultra-wealthy shell out thousands of dollars for seats at the see-and-be-seen event of New York's summer sporting calendar.

But the growing love affair between influencers and the premier American tennis event has caused some growing pains.

A chair umpire was forced to reprimand a group of patrons for staging a disruptive photo shoot while two-time US Open champion Naomi Osaka was serving during her first-round win against Anastasia Zakharova on Monday.

"Obviously if you come to a sporting event, you have to respect the sport," Osaka told reporters on Thursday after her second round win over Katerina Siniakova.

"It could be a good thing for people to make the sport of tennis popular to their specific audience, but I think it has to be managed a lot better, especially in the situation like first-round match." Another social media user attracted



Around 100 content creators were given credentials for the tournament

Sabalenka Interrupts Match Over Cannabis Smell

New York: World No. 1 Aryna Sabalenka had an unusual interruption during her US Open third-round match on Friday, stopping play to alert the umpire to a strong smell of cannabis drifting onto Louis Armstrong Stadium court.

Sabalenka raised the issue during her second service game against Uzbekistan's Kamilla Rakhimova, pointing out the smell before play resumed. "Someone is smoking weed," Sabalenka told umpire Eva Asderaki-Moore. "Would you mind to ... because it's so strong. The odour of cannabis has become a familiar — if unwelcome — feature at Flushing Meadows, with players complaining about the distraction in the past. **Reuters**

experience," said 2024 runner-up Jessica Pegula. "But I do think that it's tough when you see videos like that when they're taking pictures and using the selfie lights. People are down there trying to perform, and it's their career and their job. It seems like a bit disrespectful. "It's gotten a little maybe too much."

The trend is a direct result of the tournament's popularity, with surging attendance leading organisers to expand the main draw action to 15 days. The tournament was further expanded with the mixed doubles competition being held as a standalone event the week before singles action kicks off.

The men's ATP tour expanded its partnership with TikTok earlier this year, citing a more than 25% increase in posts under #tennis during 2025. "The more we try to raise awareness about tennis, the better it is, the more popular the sport is," said 2021 champion Daniil Medvedev.

"For sure, if it disturbs during the play, like if you see the light or something, well, you always say to the referee, can be sometimes challenging, like if during the point this happens." **Reuters**

attention for all the wrong reasons when she posted a series of photos posing inside Arthur Ashe Stadium while Keys was in the middle of playing a point against Alina Korneeva, which breached basic tennis etiquette.

"I can appreciate the influencers coming and kind of showcasing the US Open

WOMEN'S ASIA CUP

India-Pakistan Rivalry Set For Another Mismatch

Dubai: Having already secured a semifinal place, a far superior India will be expected to raise the intensity against traditional rivals Pakistan in their final league game of the Women's Asia Cup tonight.

Men's or women's, regularly scheduled India-Pakistan fixtures in multi-team events have failed to live up to the off-field hype in recent years. There is little reason to expect anything different when the two teams meet in Dubai, with overwhelming title favourites India expected to steam-roll Pakistan.

That's not to say India don't have work to do in the shortest format, having made premature exits from the last two World Cups.

They need to develop a pool of power-hitters and fast bowlers if they are

78 runs Smriti Mandhana needs to surpass Suzie Bates (4,758) for most runs in women's T20I

to challenge Australia's dominance. At the continental level, however, no team comes close to India's strength. India finished runners-up to Sri Lanka in the previous edition, while Pakistan, who beat Thailand in their opening game, remain in contention for a place in the last four.

Pakistan need a drastic improvement in their batting if they are to compete with India. Their shortcomings with the bat have let them down for several years.

Even against Thailand in their last game, Pakistan came under pressure in the power-play after losing three wickets. They eventually defended a modest 119 against the less-established side.

The team remains heavily reliant on opener Muneeba Ali and bowling all-rounder and captain Fatima Sana. **PTI**

IND vs PAK DUBAI INTERNATIONAL CRICKET STADIUM

FORM WWLWL WWLLW

Overall 14 3 In Asia Cup 6 1

LAST 5 MATCHES IND won by 64 runs 14 Jun, 2026

IND won by 6 wickets 6 Oct, 2024

IND won by 7 wickets 19 Jul, 2024

IND won by 7 wickets 12 Feb, 2023

PAK won by 13 runs 7 Oct, 2022

8pm | Sony Ten, Sony LIV

There is no advantage. The only thing is that whatever we have won against them (Pakistan), whether it is the Asia Cup or any other matches, we are always one step ahead of them. And that's it

DEEPTI SHARMA India allrounder



A Night in a Tin Box

'Container simulator' to prepare Indian athletes for unusual stay at the Asian Games in Japan

Patiala: India has gone to great lengths to give its athletes a taste of the accommodation at the Asian Games, temporarily housing them in shipping container-style units to replicate the lodgings in Japan.

Nagoya and Aichi will stage the Games from September 19 to October 4 but in a bid to cut costs there will not be an athletes' village.

Instead, the more than 17,000 athletes and officials — a bigger number than the Olympics — will stay on a cruise ship and in hotels.

There is a third type of accommodation: temporary units mostly made of wood and expected to be home to about 2,000 participants.

To prepare its competitors, the Sports



The container room in which India's Asian Games-bound athletes are set to spend a night before flying to Japan

Authority of India (SAI) on Friday unveiled similar lodgings at athlete headquarters in Patiala and Bengaluru.

Indian competitors will spend a night or two in them to get used to what lies ahead.

"These containers are like a simulator," Vineet Kumar, deputy director general of the SAI, told AFP in Patiala.

He added: "It is a unique concept as never in an Asian Games or Olympics this kind of accommodation was used. "So specifically we created this to make sure that our athletes don't feel the shock and get claustrophobic when they are given such accommodation in Japan."

The Indian containers are about 40 feet (12 metres) long and eight feet wide. They are equipped with four beds, two air conditioners, a fridge, storage tables, toilet, washroom and washing machine.

Images of the cabins in Japan show they have similar amenities.

The SAI, which arranged for journalists to visit the two cabins in Patiala and speak to athletes, says a roster has been prepared for Indian competitors to stay in the containers before flying to Japan. **AFP**

ICE Age, the Game Don of the MAGAs

White House unveils website featuring arcade games of deportations and wall-building, drawing sharp criticism from rights groups

AFP

US President Donald Trump's White House on Thursday unveiled a website featuring classic arcade games — but with a "MAGA" twist, in which players can deport migrants and build a border wall.

Rights groups swiftly criticised the release of the online games, which comes as the Trump administration steps up its mass arrest and deportation program for undocumented migrants.

One game called Rio Run — an updated version of the game Snake — features a digital version of US border czar Tom Homan chasing migrants with different skin colours next to the Rio Grande river on the Mexican border.

Another game based on the block-stacking game Tetris is called Build the Wall. "Protect the

WHITE HOUSE SAYS...

'This is an effort to further contrast between a culture of fun and winning and the dark socialist vision Democrats have for America'

border from the coming horde," the instructions say.

A third involves collecting nets to put in so-called "Trump accounts" — investment accounts containing a \$1,000 deposit for children born in 2025 through 2028.

The White House account on X posted a video with the "Make America Great Again" logo MAGA, based on the logo of video game maker Sega.

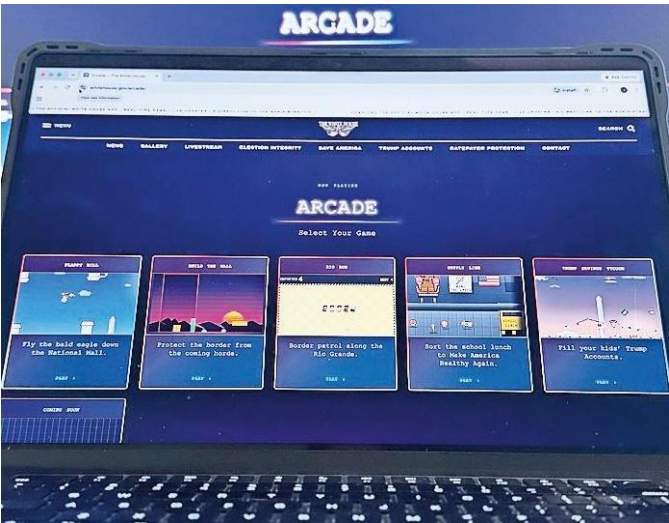
"CAN'T STOP WINNING. Build the wall. Deport. Fill a Trump Account," it says.

"This administration is laser-focused on ways to innovate and tell the story of the President's many accomplishments in a way that resonates with every American," the White House said in a statement to AFP.

"This is an effort to further contrast between a culture of fun and winning and the dark socialist vision Democrats have for America."

Rights groups criticised the White House for the gaming website.

"Makes me sick. They've been playing games with people's lives for years, now they've made a video game of what they're doing," Amerika Garcia Grewal, co-director of the Frontera Federation in Eagle Pass, Texas, told



A White House website featuring the arcade games

AFP. The game designers "have lost touch with what it means to be human and care for others".

Adriana Jasso, program coordinator for AMIGOS San Diego Community, who works at the border, said the arcade-style games showed a fundamental "lack of seriousness" from the administration.

"The cruelty, the extremity of the administration... is no longer surprising," she said.

The White House seems intent on dehumanising and ridiculing migrants, even as people die in detention centres, she said.

"This presents the issue as if it were a game, when in fact it is not."

Trump campaigned on a promise to expel millions of undocumented migrants and has taken several actions since returning to power aimed at speeding up deportations and reducing border crossings.

His White House meanwhile has long used social media stunts to ram home its points and troll liberal opponents and has sparked a backlash from several artists by using their music without permission.

NON-SEQUITUR



Silk Stalkings



Reshmi Dasgupta

A few years ago, my son and daughter-in-law presented me with a bottle of perfume for Mother's Day. The moment I sniffed the perfume, it struck an instant chord because the aroma was vividly redolent of pujas, or more specifically, the scent that lingers in the air after the rituals are done. Since then, it has become my favourite. I look for the fragrance every time I am in UK or Europe as it is not found at duty-free outlets though it belongs to a well-known scent brand.

Experts will tell you that scents activating the brain's limbic system (that controls memory, emotions and impulses) to involuntarily trigger nostalgia is often called the Proust Effect. The French writer Marcel Proust has the narrator in his novel *In Search of Lost Time* being transported back to the environs of Combray by the smell of madeleine cakes being dipped in tea. Many Bengalis feel exactly the same about thin arrowroot 'bishkoots' dipped in cha and Kolkata mornings.

The aromas listed on my gifted bottle revealed why I was transported back to my grandmother's puja room and the mellow autumnal de-

Sweet Aromas of Nostalgia

Evocative smells – olfactory-evoked autobiographical memory – drive so many of our impulses and actions

lights of our neighbourhood Durga Puja. For, while the label had foreign-sounding names like sambac, ylang-ylang and benzoin, they were actually very Indian aromas, very familiar to all desi noses: mogra, harichampa and loban or sambrani with a top note of marigold. It is as if the company had distilled puja into a bottle.

Each time I sniff it, my mind's eye sees flower-festooned gods and goddesses on the ceremonial platform dutifully dusted only by my grandmother every morning. She would gently sweep away the previous day's floral offerings — jasmine, plumeria, marigold, periwinkle, hibiscus and parijat when in season — and ash from incense sticks into a tidily scented pile to be deposited later under a plant or shrub. Then she would adorn the deities with freshly plucked blossoms.

To this day, over 30 years since she passed away, that aroma is imprinted in my olfactory memory, readily recalled at the slightest whiff. Just like shiuli (parijat flowers) coconut coir, dhuno (sal tree resin), sandalwood and ghee diyas, remind me of

Durga Puja. Clearly, I am not the only one who feels like this as many perfume companies, including several Indian ones, now offer those evocative smells, scientifically called olfactory-evoked autobiographical memory, in bottles.

Little wonder then that 'smellscape' are now regarded as an important factor in tourism.

Many visitors who fall in love with a destination are actually drawn by the sharp scent of Himalayan deodar cedars, the sweet resinous aura of the sal forests of central and eastern India or the screwpine (kewra) shrubs of coastal Odisha.

varying degrees, admittedly, most of us are olfactory tourists. Indeed, we are influenced by our noses as much as by our eyes and ears.

I was astonished to find out this week from a social entrepreneur friend in Bengal that paddy fields are redolent of rice aromas even before the crop is har-

vested. "Our three-week-old rice seedlings were smelling of Gobindobhog!" he enthused. "Each field has the distinctive scent of whichever rice variety is growing there!" Those scents are even stronger during harvest time apparently. Just hearing him describe it so vividly made my nose twitch appreciatively in anticipation.

Another friend who owns tea gardens around India and the world added that he can tell (smell!) when the second flush is ready for plucking. Of course, that grassy, herbal scent is not the same as when those harvested "two leaves and a bud" are ready for steeping in hot water after being dried and processed for drinking! Such aromas definitely must be used more widely as tourism draws: "Wake up and smell the tea in Bengal — not just the coffee in Kerala!"



Complete the grid so that numbers 1-64 connect horizontally, vertically or diagonally.

www.hidato.com

Hidato Sol.

Yesterday's puzzle solution.

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